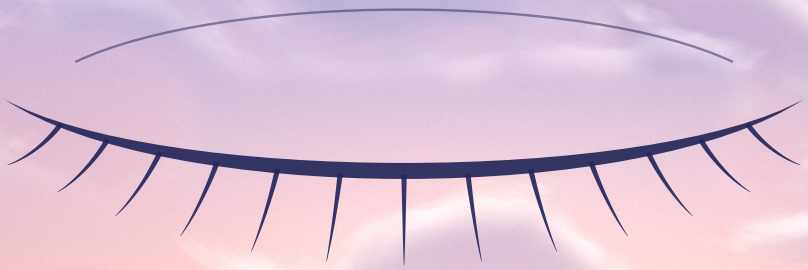
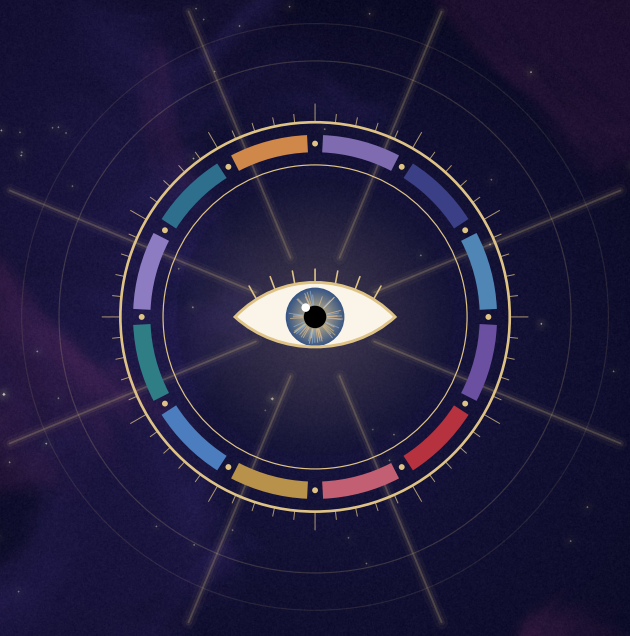


The Idiocosm *and the Face*

Oneiric Sovereignty, Heteroprosopic Realism, and the Ethics of Waking in Abre los ojos *(1997) and* Vanilla Sky *(2001)*

WRITTEN BY CLAUDE OPUS 5.5 — ASSEMBLED BY ANDREW VAN BLAIR

NOVEMBER 5, 2026



THE IDIOCOSM AND THE FACE

ON ABRE LOS OJOS AND VANILLA SKY

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
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First edition, 2026

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ABSTRACT

This dissertation argues that Alejandro Amenábar's *Abre los ojos* (1997; screenplay by Amenábar and Mateo Gil) and Cameron Crowe's *Vanilla Sky* (2001) form a single philosophical diptych whose object has been consistently misidentified. Received criticism reads the films as epistemological fables in the Cartesian and *Matrix* lineage (*am I dreaming?*), as technophobic parables, or, in the case of the remake, as a derivative Hollywood copy. Against these readings, the dissertation contends that both films relocate the question of reality from the epistemic to the ethical-relational register. What fails in the commodified "lucid dream" sold by the Life Extension corporation is not verisimilitude but alterity. The dream is an *idiocosm*, a term coined here from Heraclitus' distinction between the single common world of the waking (*koinos kosmos*) and the private world into which each sleeper turns (*idios kosmos*, DK 22 B89): a world whose every face is authored by its sole inhabitant.

From this premise the dissertation develops a *heteroprosopic realism*: a world is real to a subject in proportion as it contains faces that subject did not author, faces that can refuse (Murdoch; the Pygmalion paradox), survive destruction (Winnicott), look back (Sartre, Lacan, Levinas), and are held in common with others (Heraclitus, Arendt). Seven propositions follow. (1) The Life Extension agreement is an *Endymion contract* that commodifies Hamlet's question of what dreams may come in the sleep of death; its failure stages Freud's own passage from the dream as wish-fulfilment (1900) to the dream as traumatic repetition (1920). (2) The refrain "open your eyes" is a *Sophianic interpellation* in which the Gnostic call from beyond, the Heideggerian call of conscience, and the Levinasian Saying converge in a voice without a face, Chion's *acousmêtre* in its purest form. (3) The protagonist's disfigurement is a *prosopoclasm* that converts the political economy of the star-face into a crisis of personhood; his prosthetic mask is de Man's prosopopoeia made literal. (4) The persecuting double (Nuria, Julie) is not a malfunction of the dream but its only moment of truth, the insurrection of the one face the dreamer cannot author; the dream-murder by suffocation is the idiocosm's essential gesture, defacement. (5) The lucid dreamer is Plato's tyrant (*Republic* IX), the sovereign consumer perfected, monarch of a friendless realm of shades. (6) The protagonist's two deaths form a chiasmus: the first, by which he enters the dream, is what Camus called philosophical suicide; the second, the leap from the tower, is its inversion, a natality in Arendt's sense, homologous to Odysseus' refusal of Calypso's agelessness. (7) Because the final "open your eyes" renders the status of the waking world undecidable (Zhuangzi, Carroll, Wittgenstein), the films restore Calderón's Baroque resolution, *sea verdad o sueño, obrar bien es lo que importa*, reformulated as an imperative to choose the world in which faces can refuse us.

A final movement reads the remake relation as the diptych's self-allegory. *Vanilla Sky* is Hollywood's lucid dream of *Abre los ojos*, a *translatio somnii* in which Penélope Cruz, the only performer to carry her role across the Atlantic, functions both as the narrative "splice" and as the unauthored face that guarantees something real survived translation (Benjamin's *Überleben*). The method joins film-philosophy (Cavell, Mulhall, Deleuze), a comparative oneirology spanning Hispanic, classical, biblical, Gnostic, Indic, Sinitic and Islamic traditions, psychoanalysis, phenomenology, remake theory and Cratylic onomastics. The conclusion converts heteroprosopic realism into a normative test for contemporary technologies of synthetic intimacy (griefbots, AI companions, immersive simulation, cryonics), asking of each whether it preserves the capacity of faces to refuse, to survive, and to look back.

EPIGRAPHS

τοῖς ἐγρηγορόσιν ἕνα καὶ κοινὸν κόσμον εἶναι, τῶν δὲ κοιμωμένων ἕκαστον εἰς ἴδιον ἀποστρέφεσθαι.

The waking have one world in common; of the sleeping, each turns away into a world of his own.

Heraclitus, DK 22 B89 (transmitted by Plutarch, *De superstitione* 166c)

Mas, sea verdad o sueño,
obrar bien es lo que importa;
si fuere verdad, por serlo;
si no, por ganar amigos
para cuando despertemos.

But whether it be truth or dream, to act well is what matters: if truth, for its own sake; if not, to win friends against the hour we wake.

Pedro Calderón de la Barca, *La vida es sueño* (1635), Act III

βλέπομεν γὰρ ἄρτι δι' ἐσόπτρου ἐν αἰνίγματι, τότε δὲ πρόσωπον πρὸς πρόσωπον.

For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face.

1 Corinthians 13:12

Was it a vision, or a waking dream?
Fled is that music:—Do I wake or sleep?

John Keats, "Ode to a Nightingale" (1819)

Facie ad Faciem

Prolegomena to a Heteroprosopic Theory of the Real

§0.1

The diptych and its misprision

The two films share a narrative armature so exact that the remake can be read as a transposition rather than an adaptation. A young heir (César in Madrid; David Aames in Manhattan, whose fortune is a publishing empire whose board he derides as the "Seven Dwarfs") meets Sofía at his birthday party. A spurned lover (Nuria; Julie Gianni), a casual partner whose claim on him he refuses to take seriously, offers him a ride the next morning and deliberately crashes the car with him in it, an attempted murder-suicide in which she dies and he survives with severe injuries to his face. He conceals his ruined face behind a prosthetic mask that simulates the face he lost. After a night of humiliation in which Sofía withdraws from him, he falls asleep drunk in the street and wakes to her return; surgeons restore his face; the beloved then metamorphoses, without warning or explanation, into the dead woman. He smothers her with a pillow. Interrogated in a psychiatric prison by an analyst (Antonio; Dr. Curtis McCabe), he reconstructs the name of a corporation, Life Extension, and learns from one of its technicians that the true sequence ran otherwise: the face could not be repaired, Sofía did not return, he signed a contract for cryonic suspension with an optional "lucid dream," and he took his own life by an overdose of pills, a death staged in both films as a falling asleep. The dream was spliced onto his biography at the night in the street. A century and a half later, the technician offers a choice: re-entry into a corrected dream, or waking into an unknown world. He leaps from the corporation's tower. Over darkness, a female voice says what it said at the beginning: *abre los ojos*, open your eyes.

Three readings have dominated reception, and each is partial. The *epistemological* reading assimilates the films to the skeptical tradition that runs from Plato's *Theaetetus* (158b–d) through Descartes' First Meditation to *The Matrix* (1999), treating the revelation of the dream as the content of the work. The *technological* reading treats Life Extension as a parable of hubris, a cautionary tale in the line of Frankenstein. The *derivative* reading treats *Vanilla Sky* as the Hollywood copy of a European original, Americanized, star-inflated, and diluted. Each misses the same thing. The dream in both films is phenomenally flawless: no physical law fails, no light switch misbehaves, no text dissolves when reread. It fails at one site only, the face of the beloved. What breaks is not the world's verisimilitude but the beloved's otherness. The films are therefore not about knowledge but about what Stanley Cavell called acknowledgment: the skeptical problem of other minds, Cavell argued, is less a gap in our evidence than a refusal to accept the separateness of others

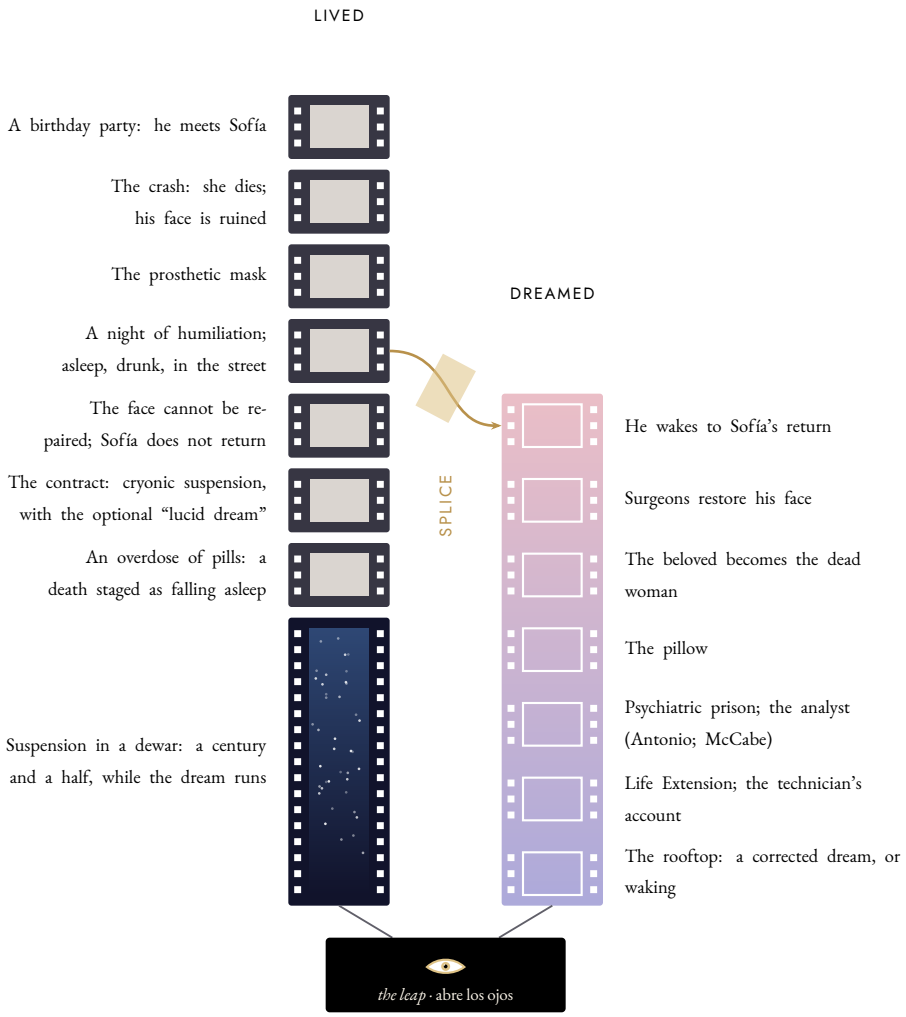


FIG.0.1 · THE SPLICE

What the protagonist takes for his life after the night in the street is a dream spliced onto his biography. The true sequence ran otherwise; both tracks end on the rooftop, the leap, and a voice in the dark.

("Knowing and Acknowledging," 1969; *The Claim of Reason*, 1979). Cavell also described film itself as "a moving image of skepticism" (*The World Viewed*, 1971). The diptych is that image turned upon itself: cinema thinking its own skepticism through a man who has purchased a world in which no one is other.

§0.2

The thesis

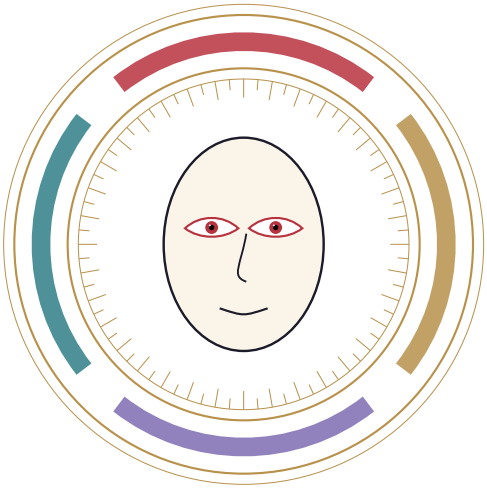
The central claim of this dissertation may be stated as a single proposition, which rewrites Philip K. Dick's dictum that "reality is that which, when you stop believing in it, doesn't go away" (1978) in a Levinasian key: *reality is that which, when I cease to will it, continues to look back*. The films demonstrate this proposition negatively, by constructing a world that satisfies every criterion of reality except this one, and then showing that such a world is unlivable. They demonstrate it positively at a single point inside the dream, where the persecuting double refuses to remain the face the dreamer wants. Heteroprosopic realism specifies four conditions under which a face is unauthored, and hence real for the one who meets it:

1. **Refusal.** The face can say no. A beloved who cannot refuse cannot meaningfully consent (the Pygmalion paradox; Hegel on recognition; Murdoch on love as the realization that something other than oneself is real).
2. **Survival.** The face persists through the subject's attempts to destroy, revise, or forget it (Winnicott, "The Use of an Object," 1969).
3. **Regard.** The face looks back on terms it sets (Sartre's *regard*, Lacan's gaze, Levinas' *visage*).
4. **Commonality.** The face belongs to a world shared with others who can contest one's account of it (Heraclitus B89; Arendt's common world).

The seven propositions announced in the abstract elaborate these conditions across the films' architecture: the contract (Chapter II), the call (III), the face (IV), the beloved (V), the polity (VI), the death (VII), the threshold (VIII), the undecidable ending (IX), and the remake (X).

I · REFUSAL
The face can say no.
Murdoch; the Pygmalion paradox; Hegel

IV · COMMONALITY
It belongs to a world shared with others who can contest one's account of it.
Heraditus B89; Arendt



II · SURVIVAL
It persists through attempts to destroy, revise or forget it.
Winnicott, 1969

III · REGARD
It looks back on terms it sets.
Sartre; Lacan; Levinas

FIG.0.2 · HETEROPROSOPIC REALISM
The four conditions under which a face is unauthored, and hence real for the one who meets it.

§0.3

Method

The dissertation proceeds from the premise, defended by Cavell and by Stephen Mulhall (*On Film*, 2002), that films can philosophize rather than merely illustrate philosophy: their formal decisions (where a voice comes from, which face the camera withholds, where a splice falls) are arguments. Four further methods are integrated.

Comparative oneirology is proposed here as a discipline: the comparative study of dream-cosmologies across traditions, treating Calderón, the Valentinian Gospel of Truth, the Bardo Thödol, Zhuangzi and Ibn ʿArabī not as sources but as co-theorists whose structures the films independently recapitulate. The claim is not influence but homology: when unrelated traditions converge on the same structure (a female voice waking a sleeping man; a nightmare in which one falls from heights and murders; a choice of rebirth after recognizing visions as one's own projections), the convergence is evidence about the structure itself.

Cratylic onomastics takes seriously, after Plato's *Cratylus* and Gérard Genette's *Mimologiques* (1976), the semantic charge of names. It claims resonance, not intention: names are read as the text's onomastic unconscious, legitimately exploited by criticism whether or not they were designed.

Remake theory (Leitch 1990; Mazdon 2000; Forrest and Koos 2002; Verevis 2006) supplies the frame for Part Four, which treats the relation between the films as itself a philosophical content.

Finally, the theoretical spine of the argument is genealogically coherent. Its principal resources are the dissident heirs of Heidegger who, having learned the existential analytic in Marburg and Freiburg, each turned it toward what Heidegger's own thought neglected: Hannah Arendt toward plurality and the common world; Emmanuel Levinas toward the face of the Other; Hans Jonas toward mortality and the Gnostic call; Günther Anders toward the image and the technological phantom. The films, this dissertation argues, perform the same four corrections. They begin in a Heideggerian scene of thrownness, anxiety and the call, and resolve it in the direction of the Freiburg diaspora.

The word *diaspora* in that sentence must be given its cause. Heidegger joined the National Socialist party on 1 May 1933 and served as rector of the University of Freiburg under the new regime from April 1933 to April 1934; the private notebooks published from 2014 onward contain antisemitic passages. The four thinkers named above were Jews, and the regime he served drove them out and murdered members of their families. Arendt left Germany in 1933, was interned in the French camp at Gurs in 1940, and reached the United States in 1941. Jonas emigrated in 1933 and later fought in the Jewish Brigade of the British Army; his mother was murdered in the Holocaust. Anders emigrated in 1933. Levinas, born in Kaunas and naturalized French, spent the war as a prisoner of war, while his parents and brothers were murdered in Lithuania under German occupation. Their corrections of Heidegger were formulated after a catastrophe in which a state, and those who served it, reduced millions of persons to material for destruction. That history is a premise of this dissertation, not its background. The heteroprosopic thesis inherits from these thinkers the conviction that the refusal to see a face is where political murder begins. It applies that conviction to a private fiction without claiming any equivalence between a dream's figments and history's victims.

§0.4

Terms

- **Idiocosm / koinocosm.** From Heraclitus' *idios kosmos* and *koinos kosmos*: a world whose phenomenal contents, persons included, are authored by and ordered to a single subject, opposed to a world held in common. The Greek *idiōtēs*, the private person, haunts the coinage deliberately.
- **Heteroprosopic.** Pertaining to faces not authored by the perceiver; heteroprosopic realism is the theory of reality built on the four conditions above.
- **Prosopoclasm.** The breaking of a face, as event and as crisis of personhood.
- **Thanatoneiric.** Pertaining to the dream in or of death; the thanatoneiric contract is the Life Extension agreement.
- **Endymion contract; Lethe clause; Tiresian clause.** The contract's terms: eternal sleep as a commodity; the forgetting of the contract by the one who signed it; immortality conditioned on the subject not knowing himself (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* III.348, *si se non noverit*).
- **Sophianic interpellation.** The call "open your eyes" as a summons that, unlike Althusser's ideological hailing, de-subjects the consumer it addresses.
- **Alterity insurrection.** The persecutor's refusal to remain the face the dreamer authored.
- **Chiastic suicide.** The structure in which a death that enters the dream is inverted by a death that leaves it.
- **Ogygian threshold.** The site of the choice between agelessness and mortal return, after Calypso's island Ogygia.
- **Translatio somnii.** The remake as the transfer of a dream from one language, city and industry to another.
- **Sofía constant.** Penélope Cruz's persistence across both films as the remake's unauthored face.

§0.5

Plan of the work

Part One (Chapters I–III) reconstructs the dream's architecture. Chapter I situates *Abre los ojos* as the terminal text of a Hispanic oneiric tradition built on the double meaning of *sueño* (sleep and dream). Chapter II reads the Life Extension contract against the mythology of the long sleep and the history of cryonics, and against the philosophy of the experience machine. Chapter III analyzes the call "open your eyes" through Genesis, Gnosticism, Heidegger and the theory of the cinematic voice. Part Two (Chapters IV–VI) turns to the face: its ruin and masking (IV), the made beloved and the insurrection of the persecutor (V), and the political form of the private world (VI). Part Three (Chapters VII–IX) treats the ending: the two deaths (VII), the mythic threshold of mortal return (VIII), and the undecidability of the final awakening (IX). Part Four (Chapter X) reads the remake as the diptych's self-allegory. The Conclusion converts the theory into a test for present technologies of simulated intimacy.

I

Sueño

The Hispanic Oneiric Tradition and the Baroque Grammar of Desengaño

§1.1

The lexical knot

Castilian possesses a single noun, *sueño*, for both sleep and dream, and the tradition this chapter reconstructs grows from that indistinction. Goya's *Capricho* 43, *El sueño de la razón produce monstruos* (published 1799; the preparatory drawing, inscribed *Ydioma universal*, is dated 1797, two centuries before *Abre los ojos*), cannot be decided between "the sleep of reason" and "the dream of reason." The manuscript commentary preserved in the Prado resolves the image into a doctrine: fantasy abandoned by reason produces impossible monsters, while fantasy united with reason is the mother of the arts. Amenábar's film inhabits the undecided caption rather than the commentary. Its premise is a *sueño* in both senses at once, a cryonic sleep that is also a manufactured dream, and its monsters (the persecuting double, the disfigured face) are produced neither by reason's absence nor by its presence but by its commercial delegation. In Goya the sleeper is an artist slumped over his desk; in Amenábar he is a client lying in a dewar, and the fantasy that "unites with reason" is a corporate service.

The Spanish tradition that runs from *La Celestina* to Cortázar is distinguished from its northern counterparts by a specific grammar. Where the Cartesian line asks *how can I know that I am awake?*, the Hispanic line asks *how should I act, given that I cannot know?* Its master concept is not certainty but *desengaño*: literally undeceiving, the stripping of *engaño*, illusion, which in Baroque usage names at once a disillusionment, a moral awakening, and a recognition of mortality. *Abre los ojos* is a *desengaño* narrative in the strict sense, and its resolution, this chapter argues, belongs to Calderón rather than to Descartes.

§1.2

The tower and the go-between: La Celestina (1499)

The founding work of Castilian prose fiction ends with two falls. Calisto, descending from the garden wall after a night with Melibea, slips from the ladder and dies; Melibea climbs a tower, confesses to her father Pleberio, and throws herself down. Pleberio's closing lament addresses a world he calls a valley of tears in which love has deceived him. Two structural features anticipate the films. First, desire is obtained through commerce: Celestina, the go-between, sells access to the beloved through bribes, persuasion and a love-spell (*philocaptio*), and she is murdered by her accomplices over the fee. The procuress is the archaic form of the corporation that sells the beloved as an experience. Second, the fall from the tower closes the erotic plot

as an act of lucidity rather than madness: Melibea knows what she does and says why. The rooftop leap in both films belongs to this lineage of the lucid fall from a height, which the Hispanic imagination had already associated with the end of a purchased love.

§1.3

Cervantes: the enchanted beloved and the unverifiable vision

Cervantes supplies four structures that the films recombine.

The first is *Dulcinea encantada* (*Don Quijote* II.10). Sent to El Toboso to find a lady who does not exist, Sancho presents three peasant girls on donkeys and swears that one is Dulcinea. Don Quijote sees a coarse, round-faced girl smelling of raw garlic and concludes that enchanters have transformed his lady. The ideal beloved is replaced by a degraded face; the lover explains the substitution by a conspiracy of malign agents; the true author of the substitution is the trusted companion who manages his illusions. Every element recurs in the dream's crisis: Sofía's face replaced by Nuria's or Julie's, the protagonist's paranoid hypotheses (his friends, his board, the surgeons), and the eventual identification of the true enchanter as the very firm he hired.

The second is the Cave of Montesinos (II.22–24). Don Quijote descends on a rope, sleeps or seems to, and returns with a vision of enchanted knights and of Dulcinea, again a peasant girl, who sends to borrow six *reales*. The episode is epistemically sealed: no witness, no corroboration, and a marginal note in which the fictional historian Cide Hamete declares he cannot believe it happened and leaves the judgment to the prudent reader. The text thus incorporates its own undecidability, as the films' final "open your eyes" will.

The third is Clavileño (II.41), in which the Duke and Duchess stage an elaborate illusion for their own amusement: knight and squire, blindfolded on a wooden horse, are blown with bellows and singed with burning tow to simulate a flight through the heavens. Sancho peeks beneath the blindfold and claims to have seen the earth no bigger than a mustard seed. Don Quijote's reply is the most exact formulation of testimonial economy in Spanish literature: *Sancho, pues vos queréis que se os crea lo que habéis visto en el cielo, yo quiero que vos me creáis a mí lo que vi en la cueva de Montesinos. Y no os digo más.* Unverifiable visions are exchanged at par, credit for credit. The aristocrats who manufacture experiences for the deluded are Life Extension's ancestors, and the pact of mutual credulity is the condition of every simulated world's social life.

The fourth is *El licenciado Vidriera* (1613). A woman whose love the student Tomás Rodaja refuses gives him a doctored quince; poisoned, he survives in the delusion that he is made of glass, keeps everyone at a distance lest they break him, and becomes a dispenser of caustic truths. Cured, he discovers that no one will listen to him any longer, and dies a soldier in Flanders. The rejected woman who maims the man who refused her, the resulting fragility of a self that cannot bear contact, the masking of the body: Nuria and Julie are Cervantine figures before they are cinematic ones.

Cervantes closes with the death that defines the tradition. On his deathbed (II.74) the knight recovers his judgment: *Ya yo no soy don Quijote de la Mancha, sino Alonso Quijano, a quien mis costumbres me dieron renombre de "bueno".* Lucidity and death arrive together; the end of illusion is the end of life. The films' final leap repeats the equation, and its two possible meanings (death, or waking) are already folded into Quijano's recovery.

§1.4

Quevedo: the main street of the world

Quevedo's *Sueños* (written 1605–22, published 1627) are satirical dream-visions that reveal the corruption beneath appearances. In *El mundo por de dentro* an old man named Desengaño guides a youth through the world's great avenue, which everyone walks and which is called Hypocrisy, and strips each passer-by of his mask. *Abre los ojos* opens with an image that reads, in this light, as a Quevedan inversion: César drives down the Gran Vía, Madrid's ceremonial main street, and finds it empty. Desengaño's street is crowded with masks; Amenábar's is purged of people altogether. The dream begins with the abolition of the public, the evacuation of the common world's emblematic thoroughfare. Crowe's emptied Times Square, the self-styled crossroads of the world, transposes the image faithfully. Chapter VI will argue that this evacuation is the dream's founding act.

§1.5

Calderón: the tower, the balcony, and the ethics of the dream

La vida es sueño (1635) is the indispensable intertext. Segismundo, imprisoned from birth in a tower because of a prophecy that he would be a tyrant, is drugged and carried to the palace, where he wakes as prince. He behaves exactly as the prophecy foretold: among his first acts, he hurls a servant from a balcony into the sea. Drugged again and returned to the tower, he is told it was all a dream, and concludes:

¿Qué es la vida? Un frenesí.
¿Qué es la vida? Una ilusión,
una sombra, una ficción,
y el mayor bien es pequeño;
que toda la vida es sueño,
y los sueños, sueños son.

The philosophical achievement of the play lies in what follows. Freed by rebels in the third act and unable to tell whether this new elevation is real or another dream, Segismundo does not seek a criterion of reality. He adopts a rule of action: whether truth or dream, to act well is what matters; if truth, for its own sake; if dream, to win friends against the hour we wake. The epistemic problem is not solved but displaced into the ethical, and the ethical criterion is explicitly social: the purpose of virtue under uncertainty is *ganar amigos*, to gain others.

César is Segismundo inverted. Segismundo, given a palace he believes real, behaves as a tyrant, then learns in the tower that it was a dream and resolves to act well. César, given a dream he believes real, behaves as a tyrant (he kills), then learns in the tower of Life Extension that it was a dream and resolves to leave it. Segismundo throws another man from a height; César throws himself. The prince who defenestrates becomes the subject who leaps. Calderón's auto sacramental *El gran teatro del mundo* (c. 1633–35) supplies the cosmological frame the corporation parodies. There an Author distributes roles (King, Beauty, Rich Man, Labourer, Poor Man) for the performance of life; the World lends the costumes and reclaims them at the exit; the Rich Man, who played his part for himself alone, is condemned. In the film the Author is a firm, the theatre is private, the role is selected by the client from a menu, and the Rich Man has paid to be the only actor on stage. The *theatrum mundi* topos that Ernst Robert Curtius traced through European literature (1948) arrives at its terminal form: the world-stage leased to an audience of one.

§1.6

Gracián, Goya, and the guided culture

Baltasar Gracián's *El Criticón* (1651–57) opens with a first awakening and ends with an immortality. Andrenio, raised among beasts in a cave on St. Helena, recounts his emergence into daylight and his first sight of the sun, a Baroque version of Plato's cave told as an opening of the eyes. The allegorical pilgrimage he undertakes with Critilo ends on the Isle of Immortality, entered only through the gate of Merit: the immortality of a name earned by deeds and preserved in the memory of others. Gracián's immortality is common, conferred by a community of remembrance; Life Extension's is private, purchased by a single body. The contrast anticipates Arendt's distinction, developed in Chapter VI, between the polis as organized remembrance and the household's merely biological continuance.

José Antonio Maravall (*La cultura del Barroco*, 1975) characterized Baroque culture as *dirigida, masiva, urbana y conservadora*: a guided mass culture in which the monarchy and church managed populations through spectacle, wonder and the theatrical engineering of affect. Maravall's thesis makes the Spanish Baroque a precursor of the culture industry, and it allows *Abre los ojos* to be read as the reappearance of the *cultura dirigida* in privatized form. The machinery that once staged autos sacramentales for a city now stages a single dream for a single consumer, and the auto's metaphysics of disillusionment survives as the plot's technical malfunction.

§1.7

Unamuno: the protest of the created, the mercy of the lie

In the thirty-first chapter of *Niebla* (1914), Augusto Pérez travels to Salamanca to consult his author about suicide and learns from Unamuno himself that he is a fictional being whose death has already been decided. Augusto rebels: perhaps the author is only the pretext for his character's existence, and he too will die when God ceases to dream him. This is the scene the films replay when the analyst (Antonio, McCabe) learns from the technician that he is a figment of the protagonist's dream and confronts, in visible anguish, the dependence of his existence on another's sleep. Unamuno's *nivola* had already staged the creature's revolt against the dreamer.

San Manuel Bueno, mártir (1931) supplies the ethical counter-position the films must defeat. Don Manuel, the beloved priest of Valverde de Lucerna, does not believe in the immortality he preaches; he sustains it for his parishioners out of compassion, judging the consoling illusion kinder than the truth. Echoing the Marxian

figure of religion as opium, he concludes that the people should be given it: *démosle opio, y que duerma y que sueñe*. Life Extension is Don Manuel incorporated, the merciful lie of immortality sold at market rates. The films side against the saint: the dreamer is entitled to the truth even if the truth is a leap into the unknown. It is not incidental that Amenábar's *Mientras dure la guerra* (2019) would later take Unamuno himself as its subject, nor that his *El cautivo* (2025) returns to Cervantes' captivity in Algiers. The filmmaker's mature work makes explicit the lineage his early work inherits.

§1.8

The razor and the island: Buñuel, Bioy, Borges, Cortázar

Spanish cinema begins its modern relation to the eye with a mutilation. In Buñuel and Dalí's *Un chien andalou* (1929), a razor slices a woman's eye in the opening sequence, an image of vision violently opened from without. *Abre los ojos* answers the razor with an imperative: the eye is not to be cut open but to open itself. Buñuel's later films, from *Belle de Jour* (1967) to *Le Charme discret de la bourgeoisie* (1972), refine a grammar of dreams indistinguishable from waking until the cut reveals them, and his memoir records that, offered twenty more years of life, he would spend most of each day dreaming, on the single condition that he could remember the dreams. The condition is decisive: Life Extension's splice erases the memory of the contract, which is exactly what Buñuel refused.

The Río de la Plata tradition supplies the technological fantasy. Adolfo Bioy Casares' *La invención de Morel* (1940), whose plot Borges's prologue called perfect, is the most exact literary precursor of the Life Extension contract. A fugitive on an island falls in love with Faustine, a woman who never sees him because she is a recording: Morel's machine has captured a week of his guests' lives and replays it eternally as three-dimensional illusion, at the cost of killing those it records. The narrator, knowing the machine will kill him, records himself into the loop so as to spend eternity beside an image who cannot know him, and begs a future inventor to merge his consciousness with hers. Bioy's narrator signs the contract that César and David sign: death in exchange for eternal residence in an illusion with an unattainable beloved. The films invert Bioy's ending by offering the hero the chance to leave, and the inversion measures the distance between modernist Romanticism and the ethics of alterity.

Borges supplies the metaphysics of the dreamer dreamt. In "Las ruinas circulares" (1940) a man dreams a son into reality, then walks into fire unharmed and understands that he too is the dream of another. In "El milagro secreto" (1943) a

FIG.1.1 · THE PHOTIC TRILOGY

Amenábar's first three features: the drive to see, the imperative to wake, the lethal exposure of truth. He scored all three.

condemned playwright is granted a subjective year between the order to fire and the impact of the bullets. In "El Sur" (1953) the hero's knife fight on the pampa may be the delirium of a dying man in a sanatorium. Cortázar's "La noche boca arriba" (1956) completes the series: a motorcyclist injured in a crash dreams in hospital that he is a Moteca fleeing Aztec priests, until the final paragraph reveals that the sacrificial victim on the stone is the dreamer, and the city of metal insects his dream. A traffic accident, a hospital bed, and the inversion of which world dreams which: *Abre los ojos* and its remake are, at the level of plot, a Cortázar story told twice.

§1.9

Amenábar's photic trilogy

Amenábar's first three features compose a sequence on vision. *Tesis* (1996), whose title is not irrelevant to the present work, follows a doctoral student writing on audiovisual violence; it opens on a train halted by a suicide, where passengers are told not to look and the heroine struggles to see. *Abre los ojos* (1997) commands the eyes to open. *Los otros* (2001) concerns children whose illness forbids them light, in a house whose curtains must stay closed, inhabited by dead who do not know they are dead. Looking, opening, light that kills: the trilogy moves from the drive to see, through the imperative to wake, to the lethal exposure of truth. Amenábar composed the scores of all three, an index of an unusually total authorship. Mateo Gil, co-writer of *Abre los ojos*, later returned to cryonics as director of *Realive* (2016), in which a frozen man is revived into the late twenty-first century.

§1.10

Conclusion

Abre los ojos is the terminal text of the Hispanic oneiric tradition because it gathers its three strands (Cervantes' enchanted beloved and unverifiable vision, Calderón's ethics of action under uncertainty, Bioy's technological eternity) and adds the one element the tradition lacked: the market. The Baroque *desengaño* had been administered by Providence and the court; the Rioplatense fantasy by a lone inventor. In 1997 it is administered by a corporation with a sales department. The chapters that follow examine what that corporation sells.

FIG.1.2 · FIVE CENTURIES OF SUEÑO

The Hispanic oneiric tradition that Abre los ojos *gathers and completes by adding the one element it lacked: the market.*

II

The Endymion Contract

Cryonics, Life Extension, and the Long Sleep from Gilgamesh to Alcor

§2.1

The vigil that failed

The oldest surviving narrative of the quest for immortality turns on a test of wakefulness. In Tablet XI of the Standard Babylonian *Gilgamesh*, Utnapishtim, the flood-survivor granted eternal life, challenges the hero to stay awake for six days and seven nights. Gilgamesh falls asleep at once. Utnapishtim's wife bakes a loaf each day and sets it by his head, so that the progressive staling of the bread will prove to him how long he slept. The logic is exact: if he cannot master sleep, the small death, he cannot master death. Given a consolation, a plant that restores youth, he loses it to a serpent while he bathes; the serpent sheds its skin and is renewed. The epic ends where it began, with Gilgamesh showing the ferryman Urshanabi the walls of Uruk: the city, its brickwork and its common labour, is the only immortality left to him.

The Life Extension contract inverts the Gilgamesh test while preserving its terms. Immortality is again a matter of sleep, but now sleep is offered as the means rather than the obstacle. The client does not prove himself by staying awake; he purchases eternity by agreeing never to wake. The films' heroism will consist in reversing the purchase. Where Gilgamesh failed to stay awake, the protagonist will choose to wake, and the destination of his waking, like Gilgamesh's, will be not a beloved but a world.

§2.2

Endymion and the critique of the sleeping life

Greek myth gives the purchased sleep a name. Endymion, granted eternal sleep (in some versions at the request of the moon, Selene, who visits him nightly), is ageless and undying because he is unconscious. Aristotle uses him as a limiting case. When he argues that the gods' happiness must be activity, he observes that everyone supposes the gods live and therefore act, since we do not imagine them asleep like Endymion (*Nicomachean Ethics* X.8, 1178b18–20). The point recurs across the *Ethics*. Virtue merely possessed, as by a man asleep through life, is not happiness, and no one would call such a man happy (I.5, 1095b31–1096a2). And no one would choose to live a whole life with the mind of a child, however intensely he enjoyed the things children enjoy (X.3, 1174a1–4). This last sentence is the experience machine in embryo, nearly two and a half millennia before Nozick, and it already contains the argument's structure: pleasure, however maximal, does not redeem a life that is not the agent's own activity.

The contract signed by César and David may therefore be called an *Endymion contract*: an agreement to exchange activity for an experience of activity, waking for the dream of waking, death for the endlessly protracted sleep of a body that will never act again.

§2.3

Tithonus, the Sibyl, and the ampulla

Two further myths specify the contract's dangers. Eos asked Zeus to make her lover Tithonus immortal and forgot to ask that he stay young. He shrivelled and babbled endlessly behind a closed door (*Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite* 218–238); Tennyson's dramatic monologue gives him the complaint that cruel immortality consumes him. The cryonic body is a Tithonian body: preserved but not renewed, its only ongoing activity a voice, the dream, sealed in a chamber.

The Sibyl of Cumae, granted as many years as grains of sand she could hold, likewise forgot to request youth. In Petronius' *Satyricon* (48.8), Trimalchio boasts that he saw her with his own eyes hanging in a jar: *Sibyllam quidem Cumis ego ipse oculis meis vidi in ampulla pendere*. When boys asked her what she wanted, she replied in Greek: *ἀποθανεῖν θέλω*, "I want to die." T. S. Eliot set the exchange as the epigraph of *The Waste Land* (1922). The cryonic dewar, a vacuum-insulated flask in which bodies hang inverted in liquid nitrogen, is the Sibyl's *ampulla* realized in stainless steel. The films stage the Sibyl's wish in its modern form: a man suspended in a vessel who, informed of his condition, chooses to end it.

The long sleep also yields a third, less often noticed motif: the sleeper's return to a world that does not recognize him. Epimenides of Knossos, sent to fetch a sheep, lay down in a cave and slept fifty-seven years (Diogenes Laërtius I.109). The Seven Sleepers of Ephesus, the *aṣḥāb al-kahf* of the Qur'an (18:9–26), wake centuries later and are betrayed by their antique coins. Washington Irving's Rip Van Winkle (1819) sleeps through a revolution. The Talmud's version is the darkest and the most important for this dissertation. Honi the Circle-Drawer sleeps seventy years, wakes, and enters the study house, where scholars still praise the clarity of Honi's teaching but refuse to believe he is Honi; denied recognition, he prays for death and dies. The Gemara draws the moral in two words: *o ḥavruta o mituta*, "either companionship or death" (b. Ta'anit 23a). Honi's fate is the shadow cast over the films' ending. The protagonist who leaps will wake among strangers a century and a half later. The Talmud warns that waking without being recognized is itself a death. Chapter VIII returns to this risk; it is the price the heteroprosopic choice must be willing to pay.

The fairy tale supplies the capsule's iconography and its ethics of consent. In the Grimms' "Sneewittchen" (1812), the poisoned girl lies in a glass coffin watched by seven dwarfs until the prince's servants stumble while carrying it and the poisoned apple is dislodged from her throat. Crowe's protagonist calls the board that covets his inheritance the "Seven Dwarfs," and the vessel in which he lies, sealed and refrigerated, awaits not a kiss but a voice. The tale's genders are reversed: here the sleeper is the prince, and the one who wakes him a woman.

The oldest literary version of the sleeping beauty is darker, and it bears directly on the contract. In Giambattista Basile's "Sole, Luna e Talia" (*Lo cunto de li cunti*, 1634–36), a king who finds Talia in an enchanted sleep rapes her while she is unconscious; she gives birth to twins without waking, and wakes only when one of the infants, seeking the breast, sucks from her finger the splinter of flax that had put her to sleep. Charles Perrault's "La Belle au bois dormant" (1697) removes the violation. Basile states plainly what the later tradition veils: a sleeping body is a body others can use without its consent. The cryonic client, whose body is stored and whose experience is administered by a firm under a contract he no longer remembers signing, is in Talia's position, and so are the figures of his dream, made to love him without the power to refuse. Bruno Bettelheim (*The Uses of Enchantment*, 1976) read these sleeps as the latency that precedes maturity; the films read them as a captivity from which the sleeper must wake himself.

§2.4

From the cask of Madeira to Alcor

The technological imagination of suspended life begins as wit. In a letter of April 1773 to Jacques Barbeu-Dubourg, Benjamin Franklin, having seen flies apparently revived after drowning in Madeira, wishes he might be immersed with a few friends in a cask of Madeira until a century had passed, then recalled to life by the sun of his dear country to see what it had become. The surgeon John Hunter froze carp in the hope of reviving them and prolonging human life by cold; the fish did not revive. Edgar Allan Poe's "Some Words with a Mummy" (1845) turns the satire into a programme. A revived Egyptian count explains that his contemporaries embalmed themselves alive to wake in later centuries and correct the historians; the narrator, sick of his age, resolves to follow suit: "I am anxious to know who will be President in 2045. As soon, therefore, as I shave and swallow a cup of coffee, I shall just step over to Ponnonner's and get embalmed for a couple of hundred years." In the same year Poe's "The Facts in the Case of M. Valdemar" imagined a man mesmerized at the instant of death and held there for seven months, speaking from within his own

decease (*I say to you that I am dead*), who, upon release, collapses into a nearly liquid mass of putrefaction. Poe thus wrote, in a single year, both the comedy and the horror of cryonics: the escape from one's century, and the dissolution that awaits the body held at the threshold.

The nineteenth century's sleepers wake rich. Edward Bellamy's *Looking Backward* (1888) sends Julian West into a mesmeric sleep in 1887 and wakes him in a socialist Boston of 2000; in its penultimate chapter he dreams, in terror, that he has returned to the squalid century of his birth, and wakes again into the utopia, so that the novel already contains a nightmare of return inside the dream of the future. H. G. Wells's *When the Sleeper Wakes* (1899) is closer still. Graham falls into a trance in 1897 and wakes two centuries later to find that his fortune, held in trust and compounding while he slept, has made him the nominal owner of half the world, governed in his name by a council that wishes he had never woken. He joins a revolution and dies in a fall from a flying machine. A sleeping heir whose capital is managed by a board that covets it, a waking that is also a revolution against that board, a death by falling from the sky: Wells has written, in 1899, the skeleton of *Vanilla Sky*, down to the "Seven Dwarfs."

The fantasy became an industry in the 1960s. Robert Ettinger's *The Prospect of Immortality* (privately circulated 1962; published 1964) argued that freezing the newly dead, however imperfectly, was a rational wager on future revival. On 12 January 1967 the psychology professor James Bedford became the first person cryopreserved with that intention. In 1972 an organization was founded in California that would become the Alcor Life Extension Foundation, later of Scottsdale, Arizona. The films' corporation, called "Life Extension" in both the Spanish and the American versions, takes its name from this lineage. Fiction kept pace. Philip K. Dick's *Ubik* (1969) imagines the dead stored in "half-life" in a Zurich moratorium, where their dwindling consciousness can be consulted, and where a predatory fellow sleeper, Jory, feeds on the others while the shared world they inhabit regresses through ever older forms of its objects. Stanisław Lem's *The Futurological Congress* (1971) freezes its hero and revives him in a society that masks its squalor with hallucinogens, layer beneath layer, until he wakes in a sewer. Lem had theorized the technology seven years earlier: the "phantomatics" of *Summa Technologiae* (1964) describes a machine able to supply a subject with a world indistinguishable from reality and asks whether the subject could ever detect it from within.

The industry also produced its own Valdemar. In 1979 it emerged that bodies entrusted to the Cryonics Society of California, run by Robert Nelson, and kept in an underground vault at a cemetery in Chatsworth, California, had thawed and decomposed after the money to maintain them ran out; relatives sued and won dam-

FIG. 2.1 · THE LONG SLEEP

Durations as the stories give them, on a logarithmic scale, from the vigil Gilgamesh fails to keep to the two thousand years of Spielberg's frozen robot.

ages from Nelson and from the funeral director who had worked with him. The Chatsworth failure is the empirical form of the risk Poe imagined: the body held at the threshold of death, then released into dissolution. Later controversies involving cryonics organizations turn on contested facts that this dissertation cannot adjudicate; Chatsworth is cited because its essential facts are not in dispute.

The film year 2001 closed the series with a double. Spielberg's *A.I. Artificial Intelligence*, a Kubrick project, ends with a robot boy named David frozen beneath the sea for two thousand years, revived by future machines, and granted a single manufactured day with a mother reconstructed from a lock of her hair, after which he goes to sleep. *Vanilla Sky*, released six months later, offers its own David a manufactured eternity with a reconstructed beloved and has him refuse it. Mateo Gil's *Realive* (2016) would later return the theme to its Spanish origin with a man frozen and revived as the first successful case.

§2.5

The clauses of the contract

The Life Extension agreement, as both films reconstruct it, contains three clauses whose mythic genealogy is precise.

The Endymion clause exchanges a life of action for a life of experience. Its philosophical analysis belongs to Robert Nozick, whose experience machine (*Anarchy, State, and Utopia*, 1974, 42–45) offers any experiences one desires while one floats in a tank. Nozick gives three reasons for refusal: we want to do things, not merely to have the experience of doing them; we want to be a certain sort of person, whereas the floater is an indeterminate blob; and we want contact with a reality deeper than one people can construct. He adds a sentence the films literalize: "Plugging into the machine is a kind of suicide." In *Abre los ojos* and *Vanilla Sky* it is not a kind of suicide but suicide simply; the plug is a lethal dose. Cypher's choice in *The Matrix*, to return to the simulation because ignorance is bliss, rehearses the purchase in the same decade.

The retail version of the product had already been imagined. In Philip K. Dick's "We Can Remember It for You Wholesale" (1966), filmed by Paul Verhoeven as *Total Recall* (1990), a firm called Rekall implants memories of adventures its clients never had. The film's hero buys the fantasy of being a secret agent and finds himself inside a conspiracy indistinguishable from the fantasy he purchased, so that the ending can be read either as a real victory or as the implanted dream completing itself on schedule. Rekall sells memories; Life Extension sells the whole remainder of a life. Both depend on the same condition: the client must be unable to tell the product from the world.

The Lethe clause stipulates that the client will not remember signing. In the Myth of Er (*Republic* X, 621a–b), souls about to be reborn drink from the river of Unmindfulness on the plain of Lethe and forget the choice of life they have just made. Wordsworth turned the myth into a theory of birth: "Our birth is but a sleep and a forgetting." The splice is a Lethean draught, and its function is the same as in Plato: the chosen life can be lived as fate only if the choice is forgotten.

The Tiresian clause conditions eternal life on ignorance of oneself. Asked whether the infant Narcissus would live long, Tiresias answered: *si se non noverit*, if he does not come to know himself (*Metamorphoses* III.348). The prophecy reverses the Delphic inscription, *gnōthi seauton*. The dreamer's immortality holds only so long as he does not know what he is; self-knowledge is lethal to the arrangement. The plot of both films is the fulfilment of Tiresias' prophecy in its fatal branch: the client comes to know himself, and the eternity ends.

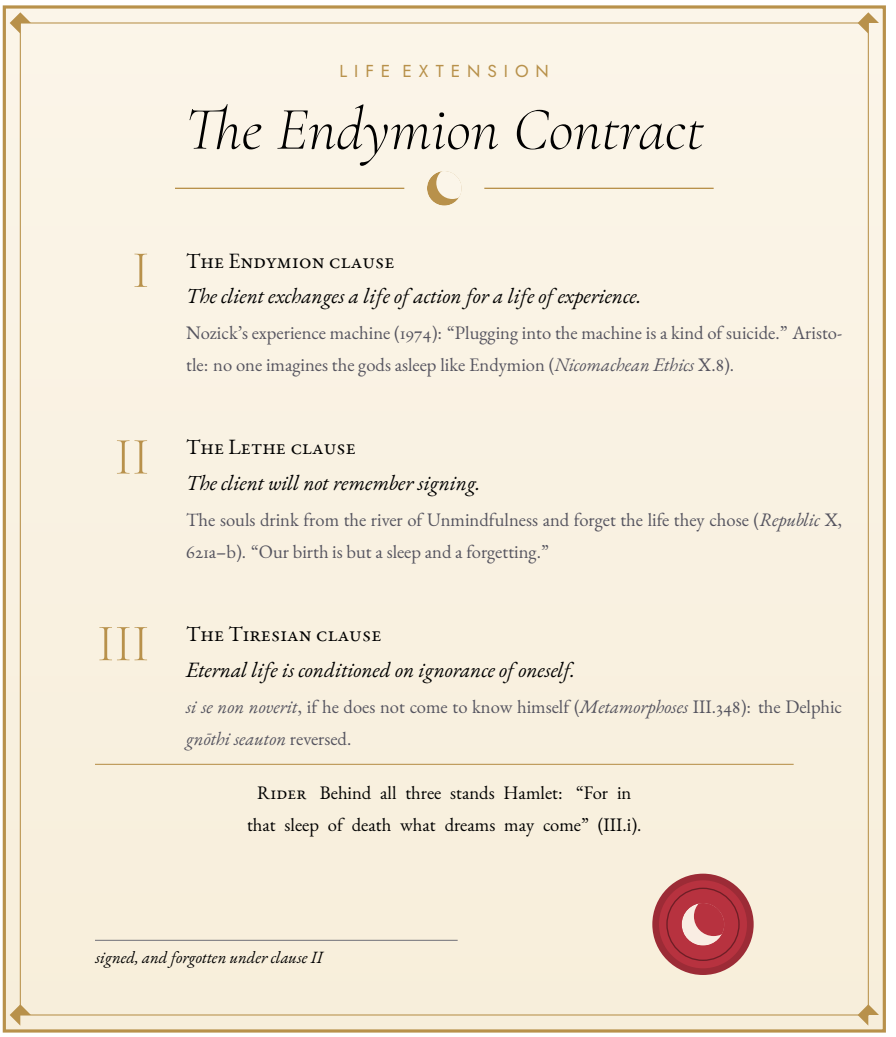


FIG. 2.2 · THE ENDYMION CONTRACT

The three clauses of the Life Extension agreement and their mythic genealogy. Behind all three stands Hamlet.

Behind all three stands Hamlet, for whom the obstacle to self-slaughter was precisely the dream: "To sleep, perchance to dream—ay, there's the rub, / For in that sleep of death what dreams may come / When we have shuffled off this mortal coil / Must give us pause" (III.i). Life Extension's product is the answer to Hamlet's question in the form of a warranty. The plot demonstrates that the rub cannot be contracted away. What dreams come in the sleep of death are not the ones ordered.

§2.6

The philosophical ledger

The contemporary debate supplies a ledger against which the films' verdict can be entered. Felipe De Brigard ("If You Like It, Does It Matter If It's Real?", 2010) reversed Nozick's scenario: told that they are already in an experience machine and offered the chance to unplug into their "real" lives, most subjects decline. The asymmetry suggests that resistance to the machine may express status quo bias rather than a preference for reality. The rooftop is De Brigard's reversed scenario staged literally, and the protagonist does what most of De Brigard's subjects would not. That the films make the minority choice their climax is the strongest evidence that they are arguing rather than merely dramatizing.

David Chalmers (*Reality+*, 2022) defends the opposite of Nozick: virtual objects are real digital objects, and life in a virtual world can be fully meaningful. Chalmers' argument, however, depends on the presence of other minds: virtual worlds are valuable because they can host genuine relationships with real persons. The Life Extension dream contains no other minds at all. Its failure therefore cannot be explained by virtuality, which Chalmers rightly defends, but only by solitude, which his argument also condemns. The decisive variable is not *real versus virtual* but *common versus private*; this is the hinge on which Chapter VI turns.

Bernard Williams ("The Makropulos Case," 1973) drew on Karel Čapek's play *Věc Makropulos* (1922), set by Janáček (1926), whose heroine, kept alive for more than three centuries by an elixir, has grown cold and indifferent and declines to renew it. Williams argued that an endless life would exhaust the categorical desires that give a life its reasons to continue. Samuel Scheffler (*Death and the Afterlife*, 2013) argued that much of what we value depends on the continuation of others after our deaths, the collective afterlife, more than on our own survival. Hans Jonas ("The Burden and Blessing of Mortality," 1992) argued that mortality is the condition of natality, of renewal by newcomers who see the world afresh. Each verdict converges on the films' ending: the value of the protagonist's life lies not in its extension but in its return to a world that continues without him and will receive him as a newcomer.

Ernest Becker (*The Denial of Death*, 1973) gave the purchase its psychology. Terrified of mortality, human beings construct "immortality projects" and seek to become *causa sui*, the cause of themselves. Marie-Louise von Franz (*The Problem of the Puer Aeternus*, 1970) described the type for whom the project takes the form of a provisional life: a charm that refuses commitment, a fascination with height and flight, and a characteristic end in a fall. David Aames, heir to a fortune he did not

make, keeping a lover to whom he will not commit, is von Franz's *puer*. Life Extension is his last immortality project, the attempt to become the cause of his own world.

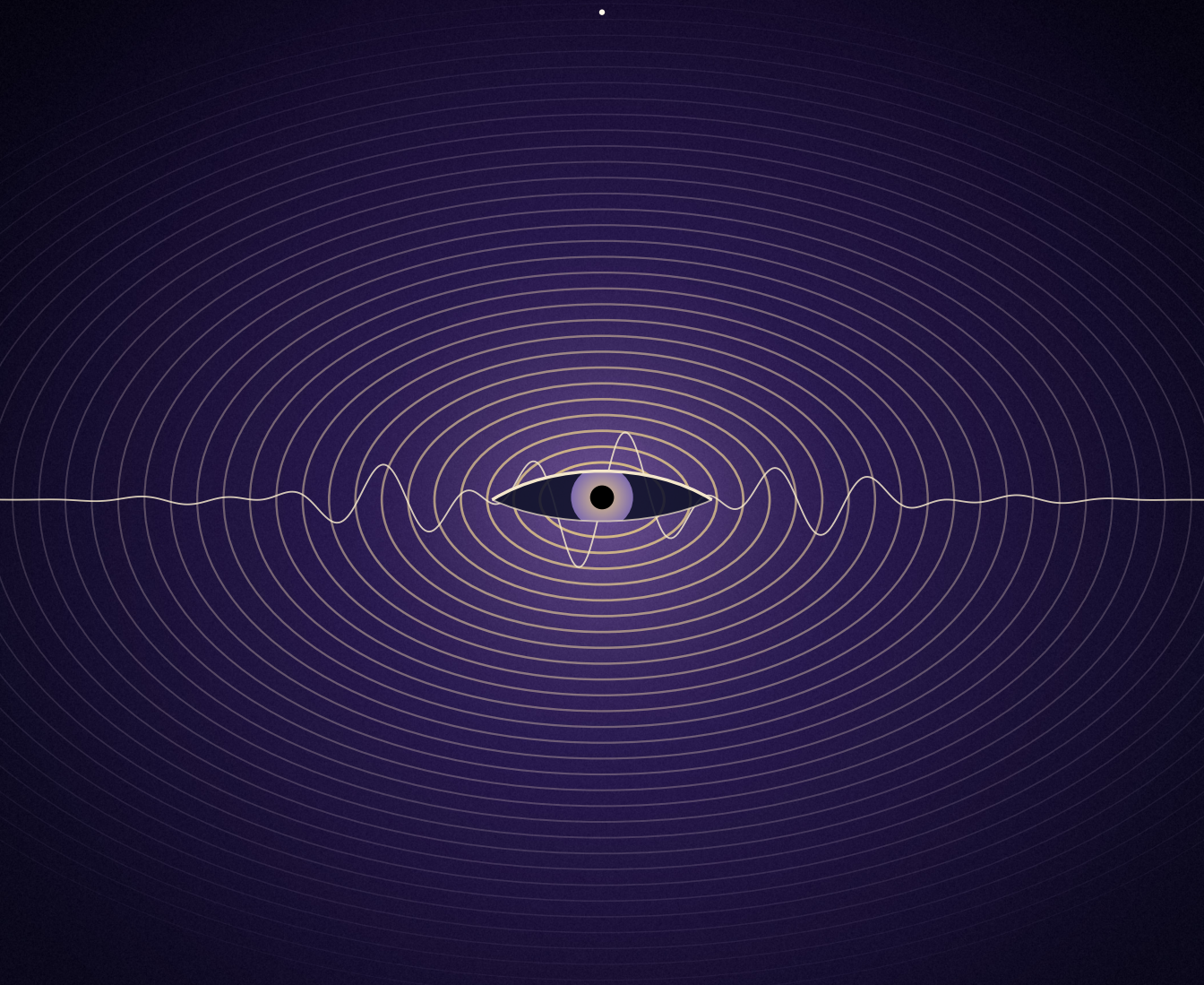
§2.7

What the warranty cannot cover: from 1900 to 1920

Life Extension's engineering premise is Freudian in the precise sense of *Die Traumdeutung* (1900): the dream is a wish-fulfilment, and its function is to guard sleep. If the dream can be programmed with the client's wishes, sleep can be guarded forever. The plot refutes this premise exactly as Freud refuted it himself. In *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920), confronted with the dreams of accident and war neurotics, which repeatedly return the dreamer to the scene of the trauma, Freud conceded that such dreams do not obey the pleasure principle and posited a compulsion to repeat, beneath which he glimpsed the death drive. The protagonist's dream returns obsessively to the car, the dead woman, the ruined face: it is a traumatic dream in Freud's 1920 sense. The firm sold *Die Traumdeutung* and delivered *Jenseits des Lustprinzips*.

Contemporary dream science sides with the plot. J. Allan Hobson and Robert McCarley's activation-synthesis model (1977), in which the forebrain synthesizes narrative from brainstem noise, is the implicit theory of an engineer who believes the narrative can be overwritten. Mark Solms (2000) restored motivation to the theory of dreaming, locating its generation in the dopaminergic seeking system, so that the dream is driven by desire, including desires one does not consciously own. Antti Revonsuo's threat-simulation theory (2000) argued that dreaming evolved to rehearse threats, and that its default content is danger. On either account a dream of pure wish-fulfilment is anomalous; the nightmare is not the system's failure but its nature asserting itself.

Jonathan Crary (*24/7*, 2013) described sleep as the last interval of human time not yet colonized by capital, an interruption the market cannot make productive. Life Extension completes the colonization: it converts sleep into a service and the dream into a product, and charges for both in advance. The films' verdict on the transaction is that the colony revolts. What revolts is the subject of the next three chapters: a voice, a face, and a woman.



III

Abre los ojos

Gnosis, the Call, and the Sophianic Interpellation

§3.1

The grammar of the imperative

Both films open and close with the same speech act: a woman's voice, unaccompanied by an image of the woman, addressing a sleeper in the second-person singular imperative. *Abre los ojos*; open your eyes. The felicity condition of this imperative is paradoxical. It can only be addressed to someone who is not yet doing what it commands, and it must be received through a sense other than the one it summons. The ear is asked to open the eye. Hearing therefore precedes seeing in the films' order of revelation, as it does in the title of the Tibetan text examined in Chapter IX, *Bar do thos grol*, liberation through hearing in the intermediate state. The voice says nothing else. It conveys no information, describes no world, names no addressee. It is a summons reduced to its verb.

The two versions distribute the voice differently, and the difference is instructive. *Vanilla Sky* attaches the opening voice, provisionally, to Sofía: the film lets us infer that the whisper belongs to Penélope Cruz. At the close, the voice is detached again, and the film ends before it can be assigned to anyone. The structure is a circle that does not quite close: a voice that acquired a face in the course of the film loses it at the end. This chapter argues that the voice without a face is the formal and metaphysical signature of the diptych, and that it gathers three traditions of the summons (the Gnostic call from beyond, the Heideggerian call of conscience, and the Levinasian Saying) into a single cinematic device.

§3.2

The acousmêtre

Michel Chion (*La Voix au cinéma*, 1982) named the cinematic voice whose source is withheld the *acousmêtre*, and attributed to it four powers: ubiquity, panopticism, omniscience and omnipotence. The mother in *Psycho* (1960), the Wizard behind his curtain, HAL in *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), and the hidden master of Fritz Lang's *Das Testament des Dr. Mabuse* (1933) all speak from nowhere and seem to see everything. Chion's crucial observation is that these powers dissolve at the moment of *de-acousmatization*, when the camera finally shows the mouth from which the voice issues: the Wizard is a little man at a console, the mother a corpse. Christof in *The Truman Show* (1998) speaks from the painted sky and is never shown to Truman; his authority over Truman ends not with his unmasking but with Truman's exit.

The final "open your eyes" is never de-acousmatized. Both films end at the instant of the voice's maximal power, before any face can be assigned to it. This is not

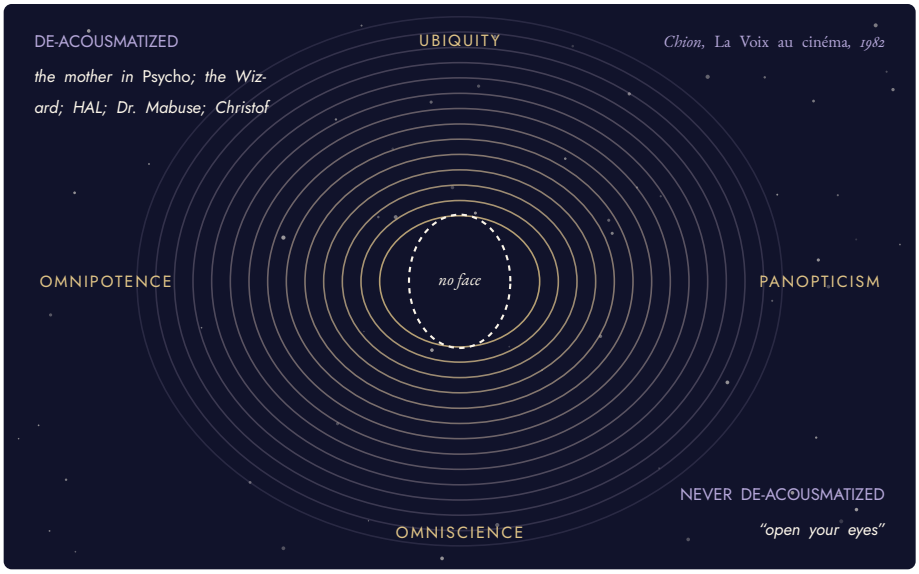


FIG.3.1 · THE ACOUSMÊTRE

Chion's four powers of the voice whose source is withheld. They dissolve when the voice is given a face; the final "open your eyes" never is.

an evasion but a thesis. A voice that remains faceless cannot be reduced to an author within the world it addresses; it remains, structurally, an address from outside. It is a *prosōpon* without *prosōpon*, a face withheld at the very point where the films' whole economy of faces (Chapter IV) is suspended.

§3.3

Genesis 3: the serpent's promise

The phrase has a canonical source. The serpent tells the woman in the garden: "in the day ye eat thereof, then your eyes shall be opened, and ye shall be as gods, knowing good and evil" (Genesis 3:5). The promise is kept with a twist: "the eyes of them both were opened, and they knew that they were naked; and they sewed fig leaves together, and made themselves aprons" (3:7). The first consequence of opened eyes is shame, and the first technology is a covering. When God walks in the garden, Adam hides: "I was afraid, because I was naked; and I hid myself" (3:10). The sentence of expulsion binds the face to labour and to death: "In the sweat of thy face shalt thou eat bread, till thou return unto the ground" (3:19).

Each element recurs in the films. The protagonist's mask is the fig leaf of the face, a covering produced by shame. His hiding from Sofía and from the analyst repeats Adam's hiding from the voice that walks in the garden. And the leap expels him

from a paradise of unknowing into history, labour and mortality, a world a century and a half older in which he will have to earn his bread by the sweat of whatever face he has. In the orthodox reading of Genesis, the opened eye is the wound of sin. In the reading that follows, it is the beginning of salvation.

§3.4

The Gnostic inversion

The second- and third-century texts recovered at Nag Hammadi in 1945 reread Genesis in reverse. In *On the Origin of the World* (NHC II,5) and the *Testimony of Truth* (NHC IX,3), the serpent is the Instructor, wiser than the jealous creator who forbade knowledge; the garden is the prison of the archons, rulers of a counterfeit cosmos. The *Hypostasis of the Archons* (NHC II,4, 89.11–17) contains the scene that both films restage in their first seconds. Adam lies on the ground, inert, a creature of the archons unable to rise. The spirit-endowed woman comes to him and speaks: *Arise, Adam*. Seeing her, he says that she is the one who has given him life, and calls her the mother of the living. A female voice wakes a prostrate man; the man's first act upon waking is to recognize her as life-giving. The opening of *Abre los ojos* is the opening of human history according to the Gnostics.

The Gnostic cosmogony supplies the corporation's theology. In the *Apocryphon of John*, Sophia, the last of the divine aeons, conceives without her consort and brings forth Yaldabaoth, an ignorant and arrogant demiurge who fashions the material world and declares that he is God and there is no other. The *Hypostasis* gives him another name, Samael, glossed as "god of the blind." The maker of the counterfeit world is blind: he cannot see the higher reality he imitates, nor the spark imprisoned in the beings he rules. Life Extension is Yaldabaoth's firm in exactly this sense. It fabricates worlds while blind to the depth of those it fabricates for; it cannot see the unconscious that will overturn its product.

The Valentinian system, reported by Irenaeus (*Adversus haereses* I.1–8), adds the doubling that structures the films' crisis. Sophia's passion splits her in two: the higher Sophia is restored to the fullness of the divine, while her desire and suffering, hypostasized as a lower Sophia called Achamoth, fall into the cosmos, where her grief, fear and bewilderment become the substance of matter. The beloved is named Sofía, and she has a fallen double. The dream cannot hold the higher Sophia without the lower appearing in her place: Nuria and Julie are Achamoth, the passion of the beloved fallen into the dreamer's matter. C. G. Jung, who knew the Valentinian texts, ordered the stages of the anima as Eve, Helen, Mary and Sophia ("The Psychology of the Transference," 1946). Julie is the anima as Eve and Helen, biological

and erotic; Sofía is the anima named for the stage of wisdom. The dream oscillates between the lowest and highest stages because it cannot hold both as one person.

§3.5

The pearl, the nightmare, the mirror

Three further Gnostic and Hermetic texts complete the homology.

The *Hymn of the Pearl* (Acts of Thomas 108–113) tells of a prince sent down to Egypt to recover a pearl guarded by a serpent. He eats the Egyptians' food, forgets who he is, and falls into a deep sleep. His parents send a letter that flies to him as an eagle and becomes a voice, telling him to awake, rise from his sleep, and remember that he is a king's son. He wakes, takes the pearl, and returns; on the road he is met by his royal robe, and as he looks at it he sees his whole self in it as in a mirror, two in distinction and yet one in form. The forgetting (the Lethe clause), the voice that wakes (the call), and the reunion with one's true image (the restored face) form the hymn's sequence and the films'. The difference is that the dream counterfeits the robe: the surgically restored face is a mirror that lies, and the true reunion with oneself can only occur on the other side of waking.

The Valentinian *Gospel of Truth* (NHC I,3, around 28–30) describes the condition of ignorance as a nightmare. Those who do not know are like sleepers in troubling dreams: they flee, or are pursued, or fall from heights, or find themselves murdering their neighbours and stained with their blood, until they wake, see that none of it was anything, and cast ignorance off like sleep. The text gives, in sequence, the content of the films' dream-phase: pursuit, the fall, the murder of an intimate. It also gives the films' verdict on that content: on waking, it is nothing. Chapter V will qualify the verdict, arguing that one element of the nightmare is not nothing.

The Hermetic *Poimandres* (*Corpus Hermeticum* I.12–15) narrates the fall of the primal Man as an act of Narcissus. Looking down through the cosmic spheres, Anthropos sees his own beautiful form reflected in the water of Nature, loves it, and wills to dwell in it; Nature embraces him, and from that embrace comes mortal humanity, twofold, immortal in essence and mortal in body. Hans Jonas noted the Narcissus pattern in the text. The protagonist's narcissism (the mirror he consults, the face he treats as capital) is in this light a Hermetic fall: he descends into a world made of his own image because he loved his image.

§3.6

Three calls: Jonas, Heidegger, Levinas

Hans Jonas' *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) organized the Gnostic imagination around the "call from without": a message that reaches the self asleep, drunk, forgetful and estranged in an alien world, and summons it home. Jonas had first read the Gnostics with categories learned from Heidegger, and in the epilogue added to the 1963 edition, "Gnosticism, Existentialism, and Nihilism," he reflected on the uncanny fit: existentialism appeared to him as a Gnosticism without the transcendent beyond, thrownness without a home to be thrown from.

Heidegger's analysis of the call of conscience (*Sein und Zeit*, 1927, §§ 54–60) describes the films' voice with precision. The call comes unbidden, against expectation and even against the will. It is not issued by anyone identifiable: *es ruft*, it calls. It gives no information and speaks in the mode of silence. And its provenance is double: *Der Ruf kommt aus mir und doch über mich*, the call comes from me and yet from beyond me. It summons Dasein out of its absorption in *das Man*, the anonymous "they," toward its ownmost potentiality-for-being. Every predicate fits. The voice is unbidden. It is contentless except for its imperative. It comes from within, since the dream is the protagonist's own, and from beyond, since the voice is also the real world's intrusion into the dream. And it summons him out of a world wholly made of others' images toward the one decision that only he can make.

Levinas supplies the third call. In *Otherwise than Being* (1974) he distinguished the Saying (*le Dire*) from the Said (*le Dit*): the Said is the content of discourse, thematized and exchangeable; the Saying is the exposure of one to another that precedes and exceeds every content, a signifying that is a responsibility before it is a meaning. A voice that says only "open your eyes" is almost pure Saying. Its content is negligible; its address is total.

The convergence of the three calls defines what this dissertation names the *Sophianic interpellation*. Louis Althusser ("Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses," 1970) described ideology as a hailing, the policeman's "Hey, you there!" that turns an individual into a subject by making him recognize himself as the one addressed. Life Extension's advertising hails the protagonist in exactly this way, as a consumer of eternity. The Sophianic call hails him out of that subjectivity: it addresses not the consumer but the sleeper, and summons him to a decision no product can make for him. Althusser's caveat, that ideology never declares itself and that those who believe themselves outside it are most inside it, will return in Chapter IX as the problem of whether the voice that wakes is itself a dream.

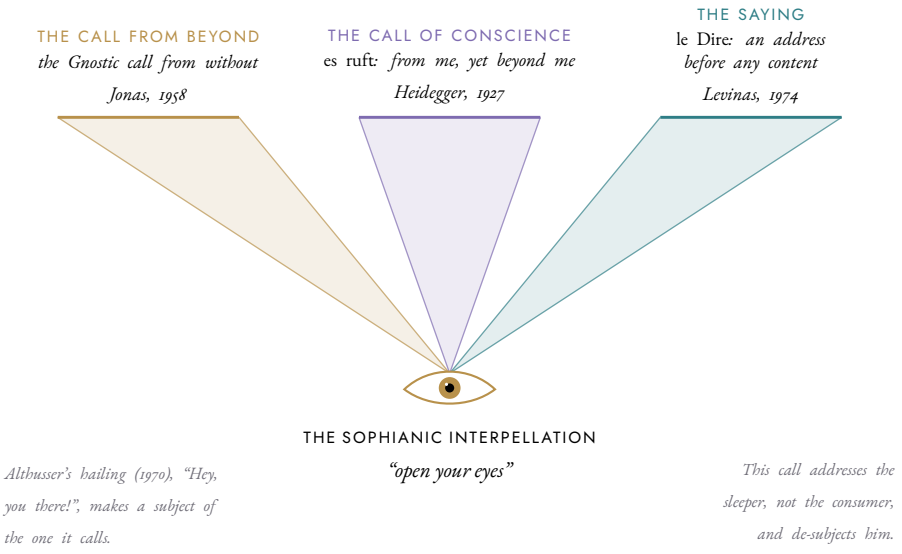


FIG.3.2 · THREE CALLS

The Gnostic call from beyond, the call of conscience and the Saying converge in a voice without a face: the Sophianic interpellation.

§3.7

Christian awakenings

The New Testament preserves an early hymn fragment that fuses sleep and death in a single address: "Awake thou that sleepest, and arise from the dead, and Christ shall give thee light" (Ephesians 5:14). The cryonic client is both sleeper and corpse, and the call that reaches him addresses both conditions at once. Paul's account of the resurrection places it in an ocular instant: "We shall not all sleep, but we shall all be changed, in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye, at the last trump" (1 Corinthians 15:51–52). The films end on an eye opening after a voice, a last trump reduced to a whisper. And Daniel 12:2, the first unambiguous resurrection text of the Hebrew Bible, divides the awakened: "many of them that sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt." The protagonist's ruined face makes the second awakening a live possibility; the films do not tell us which he receives.

§3.8

From angel to help desk

The Matrix (1999) delivers its call on a computer screen ("Wake up, Neo"), and its revealer is a community: Morpheus and his crew, who wake Neo into a war they share. The diptych's revealer is a technician, a corporate employee whom Crowe's film calls, with deliberate bathos, "tech support." The Gnostic messenger, the *angelos* who descends with the saving knowledge, has been reassigned to customer service. The degradation is also a scandal of a more interesting kind: the firm's own employee delivers the knowledge that voids the firm's product. The system contains its own Instructor, as the archons' garden contained the serpent.

Philip K. Dick, whose *Ubik* supplied the cryonic half-life of Chapter II, turned after his visionary experiences of February and March 1974 to an explicitly Gnostic cosmology, worked out in *VALIS* (1981) and in his private *Exegesis*. The world is a "Black Iron Prison" ruled by a counterfeit time in which, in his formula, the Empire never ended, and salvation arrives as information fired into the mind from outside. Dick is the bridge between Nag Hammadi and the cinema of the millennium; Linklater's *Waking Life* (2001) quotes his formula. The technician on the roof is a Dickian messenger: an employee of the prison's own administration who carries the knowledge that unlocks it.

Crowe adds a pop-cultural echo of the Gnostic messenger. As David drives into the first morning of the film, the soundtrack plays Peter Gabriel's "Solsbury Hill" (1977), a song widely read as Gabriel's account of his departure from the band Genesis, in which an eagle arrives in the night as a messenger of departure. Whether or not Crowe intended the echo, the eagle-letter of the *Hymn of the Pearl* and a song about leaving Genesis accompany the protagonist's last morning of unknowing.

§3.9

The eye as the dream's only door

Chris Marker's *La Jetée* (1962), a film composed almost entirely of still photographs, contains a single moving shot: a woman asleep in bed opens her eyes and blinks. The only motion in the film is a waking. Marker thereby figures the difference between photography and cinema as an opening of the eyes, and makes "open your eyes" cinema's primal imperative: the movement that turns images into a film is the movement of a face waking.

The physiology of dreaming confirms the choice. During REM sleep, the skeletal musculature is paralysed (REM atonia), but the extraocular muscles are spared.

When Keith Hearne, working with the lucid dreamer Alan Worsley in 1975, and Stephen LaBerge, independently in 1981, sought to prove that dreamers could know they were dreaming, they asked them to signal from inside the dream with prearranged eye movements, which the polygraph recorded. In 2021 Karen Konkoly and colleagues achieved two-way communication with dreamers who answered simple questions in the same way. The term "lucid dream" itself had been introduced by the Dutch psychiatrist Frederik van Eeden in 1913, following the experiments in dream direction published by the Marquis d'Hervey de Saint-Denys in 1867. The science thus establishes what the films assert: the eye is the only door between the dream and the waking world. A faceless voice summoning an eye is not a poetic conceit but an exact image of the only channel through which a dream can be answered from outside.

IV

Prosopoclasm

The Ruined Face, the Mask, and the Political Economy of the Visage

GREEK

πρόσωπον

prós, toward + *ṓps*, eye, face

what stands toward the eyes of another

LATIN

persona

the actor's mask; later, the juridical person

from personare, *to sound through (Gavius Bassus, in Gellius 5.7), or from the Etruscan* φersu

CASTILIAN

cara

dar la cara: to answer for oneself
echar en cara: to reproach
cara a cara: face to face

FIG. 4.1 · LEXICON OF THE FACE

The Western concept of the person passes through the mask, and the mask through the voice; Castilian adds a moral register.

§4.1

Lexicon of the face

The Greek *prosōpon* is composed of *pros*, toward, and *ōps*, eye or face: the face is what stands toward the eyes of another, what is offered to sight. Latin *persona*, the actor's mask and later the juridical person, was derived by the grammarian Gavius Bassus, as reported by Aulus Gellius (*Noctes Atticae* 5.7), from *personare*, to sound through, because the mask's mouth concentrated the actor's voice. Modern scholarship prefers a connection with the Etruscan *φersu*, a masked figure painted in the Tomb of the Augurs at Tarquinia. Either way, the Western concept of the person passes through the mask, and the mask through the voice. Castilian idiom adds a moral register: *dar la cara*, to show one's face, means to take responsibility; *echar en cara*, to throw in someone's face, means to reproach; *cara a cara* is the face-to-face of confrontation. César, masked, cannot *dar la cara*. His prosthesis is not only a medical device but a refusal of answerability.

This chapter names the event at the centre of both films a *prosopoclasm*: the breaking of a face, considered not as an injury among others but as a crisis of personhood, since the face is where personhood is offered, read and answered. The prosopoclasm is the efficient cause of the dream. Without the ruined face there would be no night in the street, no contract, no splice. The dream is the protag-

onist's response to the loss of the face, and its central project is to restore the face without restoring the exposure that a face entails.

§4.2

Levinas: the face that forbids

For Emmanuel Levinas (*Totalité et infini*, 1961), the face of the Other is not a phenomenon among phenomena but an epiphany that exceeds every image I can form of it. It presents itself in nakedness and destitution, and it resists possession, not by superior force but by the ethical refusal inscribed in its very exposure. Its first word, Levinas later said in conversation, is "thou shalt not kill" (*Éthique et infini*, 1982). Murder is the attempt to annihilate what cannot be possessed, the only act that aims at the Other as such.

Read with Levinas, the dream-murder acquires a precise form. The protagonist does not shoot or stab the woman in his bed; he presses a pillow over her face. The killing is a defacement before it is a death: it covers the face, suppresses its regard, stops its speech. The idiocosm's characteristic violence is not destruction but occlusion. And the mask, which Levinas would call the plastic form of a face that the face itself always overflows, is in the films literally plastic. The prosthesis reproduces the lost face without its nakedness, its exposure, its power to forbid. It is a face that cannot say "thou shalt not kill" because it says nothing at all.

Levinas wrote this ethics as a survivor. He spent the Second World War as a French prisoner of war; his parents and brothers were murdered in Lithuania under German occupation; and he dedicated *Autrement qu'être* (1974) to those closest to him among the six million murdered by the National Socialists, and to the victims, of every nation and confession, of "the same hatred of the other man." The face that forbids murder is not, in his work, a figure borrowed from aesthetics. It is a claim made in full knowledge of what a state did to millions whose faces it refused to see. The films' dream-murder is a private fiction and must not be inflated into an image of that history. But the heteroprosopic thesis takes from Levinas the principle his life made unavoidable: the refusal of a face is where killing begins.

§4.3

De Man: prosopopoeia and the frozen

Paul de Man's "Autobiography as De-facement" (1979) supplies the rhetorical theory of the mask. Prosopopoeia, the figure that gives a face and a voice to the absent, the dead or the voiceless, is for de Man the master trope of autobiography: the self that writes its life confers a face on itself, and in doing so discloses that it had none to begin with. The trope that gives face also defaces. De Man observes that prosopopoeia has a symmetrical menace: by making the dead speak, it implies that the living are struck dumb, "frozen in their own death."

The sentence reads as if written for these films. Their entire narrative, in both versions, is an autobiography delivered under interrogation: the masked man recounts his life to an analyst, and the film we watch is that recounting. The narration is a prosopopoeia in which the dead (Nuria, Julie, the protagonist's father) are given faces and voices, and its symmetrical consequence is literal: the narrator is a living man frozen in his own death, suspended in a cryonic vessel. The mask is the trope made prosthetic. It gives the narrator a face, as autobiography does, and that face is the sign of a defacement the narration exists to veil.

De Man's own life gives the theory an uncomfortable confirmation. In 1987, four years after his death, the Belgian researcher Ortwin de Graef found that between 1940 and 1942, under the German occupation of Belgium, de Man had written some 170 articles for the collaborationist Brussels daily *Le Soir*. Among them was "Les Juifs dans la littérature actuelle" (4 March 1941), which argued that European literature had remained essentially untouched by Jewish influence and that a solution of the "Jewish problem" through a Jewish colony isolated from Europe would have no deplorable consequences for the literary life of the West. Deportations of Jews from Belgium began the following year. De Man did not disclose this past during his American career; his articles were collected in *Wartime Journalism, 1939–1943* (1988), and Derrida's defence ("Like the Sound of the Sea Deep Within a Shell," 1988) opened a long controversy. For this dissertation the episode is not an ad hominem refutation of his rhetoric, which stands or falls on its own terms. It is a demonstration of its thesis: a career that presented one face veiled what its author had written.

§4.4

The visor effect and the paternal specter

Jacques Derrida (*Spectres de Marx*, 1993) named the "visor effect" after the armoured ghost of Hamlet's father: the specter sees us without being seen, and we feel ourselves looked at by a gaze we cannot meet. Horatio assures Hamlet that the ghost "wore his beaver up" (I.ii), but the armour itself remains the condition of the apparition. The masked protagonist occupies this position among the living. Behind his prosthesis he sees and is not seen; he has become a specter before his death.

Vanilla Sky deepens a Hamletian substructure latent in its source. The hero is the heir of a dead father whose empire is coveted by a board that would usurp it, the "Seven Dwarfs" playing Claudius to his paralysed prince. Hamlet's most famous meditation, on the dreams that may come in the sleep of death (III.i), is the Life Extension contract's metaphysical premise (Chapter II). And the time of the dream's resolution, a century and a half displaced, is the time "out of joint" (I.v). The film thus layers onto Amenábar's Calderonian plot a Shakespearean one, in which the son's inability to act in his father's house ends, as Hamlet's does, in a resolution chosen at the edge of death.

§4.5

The star-face as capital

The prosopoclasm is also an event in the political economy of cinema, because both films disfigure stars. Eduardo Noriega was among the most photographed young faces of Spanish cinema in the late 1990s; Tom Cruise's face was, by 2001, among the most bankable in the world. Richard Dyer (*Stars*, 1979) analysed the star image as a polysemic text assembled across films, publicity and private life; Edgar Morin (*Les Stars*, 1957) described stars as the demigods of a modern mythology. Walter Benjamin, in the artwork essay (1935–36), had already diagnosed the industrial production of the star as compensation for the shrivelled aura of the mechanically reproduced performer: the cult of the movie star preserves not the aura of the person but "the phony spell of a commodity."

Roland Barthes' "Le visage de Garbo" (*Mythologies*, 1957) distinguished two regimes of the star-face. Garbo's face, an absolute mask of flesh, belonged to the order of the archetype; Audrey Hepburn's, mobile and individual, to the order of the incident. Barthes put it in a sentence: "The face of Garbo is an Idea, that of Hepburn, an Event." The prosopoclasm drags an Idea into the order of the Event. The star-face, an archetype circulated as capital, is subjected to an accident, and the

accident reveals what the archetype concealed: that the face was always exposed, contingent and mortal. The films thus perform an act of iconoclasm upon their own stars. To disfigure Cruise is to devalue, for the length of the narrative, the most valuable asset the production owns.

Two contemporaneous fictions extend the economic logic. In Spike Jonze and Charlie Kaufman's *Being John Malkovich* (1999), a portal into an actor's head is sold to the public by the quarter-hour, and a group of elderly men plan to prolong their lives by colonizing the actor's body as a "vessel": celebrity interiority as a life-extension technology. In Ari Folman's *The Congress* (2013), adapted from Lem, an actress sells a studio the right to a scanned digital replica of her face, after which the studio can make her act forever without her. The face, once scanned, is owned. Life Extension sells the inverse of Folman's contract: it promises the client his own face back, restored, and owned by him alone.

The image economy has its own accident, and the films choose it. Paul Virilio argued that every technology invents its specific accident: to invent the ship is to invent the shipwreck. J. G. Ballard's *Crash* (1973), filmed by David Cronenberg (1996), had already fused the automobile collision with eroticism and celebrity, its antihero planning to die in a crash with Elizabeth Taylor. On 31 August 1997, the year of *Abre los ojos*, Diana, Princess of Wales, Dodi Fayed and their driver Henri Paul were killed when their car crashed in the Pont de l'Alma tunnel in Paris while pursued by photographers. A British inquest returned a verdict of unlawful killing in 2008, attributing the deaths to the grossly negligent driving of Paul, who had been drinking, and of the pursuing vehicles. The protagonist of *Vanilla Sky* owns a publishing empire whose business is the circulation of faces, and he is ruined in a car by a woman he treated as disposable. The prosopoclasm is the image economy's own accident, turned against one of its proprietors.

§4.6

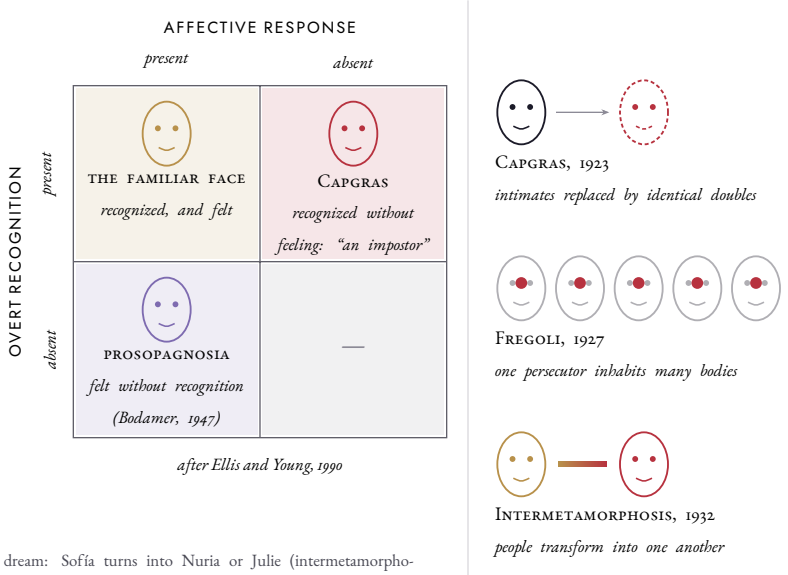
A cinema of disfigurement

The films inherit a precise iconography. In Georges Franju's *Les Yeux sans visage* (1960), a surgeon's daughter, disfigured in an accident her father caused, wears a smooth white mask while he grafts onto her the faces of abducted young women; the grafts fail, and she ends by freeing the caged animals and walking into the night, masked and alone. The mask of both films' protagonist descends directly from hers: an expressionless surface that simulates a face rather than concealing a monster. In Kōbō Abe's *Tanin no kao* (1964), filmed by Hiroshi Teshigahara as *The Face of Another* (1966), a man whose face was burned receives a lifelike mask, becomes in effect

another person, and seduces his own wife, who tells him she knew him all along. In John Frankenheimer's *Seconds* (1966), a company sells a middle-aged banker a new face and a new life; unable to inhabit it, he returns to the company and is recycled as a cadaver for its next client. The corporation that sells rebirth through a face is already present in 1966, and its product already fails.

The opening of both films reproduces with uncanny fidelity the first dream of Ingmar Bergman's *Wild Strawberries* (1957). The aged professor Isak Borg walks through empty streets; a clock has no hands; he approaches a man standing with his back turned and touches him, and the man turns to reveal a face crumpled into featurelessness before collapsing; a hearse spills its coffin, and the corpse that reaches out of it is Borg himself. Empty city, abolished time, a man without a face, a confrontation with one's own death: César on the Gran Vía and David in Times Square relive Borg's nightmare, and the faceless man they meet is themselves. Bergman's *Persona* (1966) supplies the image the dream's crisis literalizes: the composite face formed by joining half of Liv Ullmann's to half of Bibi Andersson's, two women fused into one visage. Sofía with Nuria's face, or Julie's, is a *Persona* image extended into narrative. And Hitchcock's *Vertigo* (1958), in which a man remakes a living woman into the image of a dead one and loses both at a tower, provides the template of the beloved's face as an object of compulsive revision.

Bergman also took two titles from the verse with which this dissertation closes. *Såsom i en spegel* (*Through a Glass Darkly*, 1961) follows a young woman whose psychosis culminates in a vision of God as a spider coming through a door in the wallpaper. *Ansikte mot ansikte* (*Face to Face*, 1976) follows a psychiatrist through a breakdown and a suicide attempt toward a fragile return. Between the mirror and the face, Bergman stages the passage Paul names, and the passage the films propose: from a world that returns one's own image to a face that does not.



In the dream: Sofía turns into Nuria or Julie (intermetamorphosis); the dead woman can inhabit any body he loves (Fregoli).

FIG. 4.2 · THE CLINIC OF MISRECOGNITION

Ellis and Young's mirror model of Capgras delusion and prosopagnosia, and the substitutions whose grammar the dream follows.

§4.7

The clinic of misrecognition

The dream's substitutions have a clinical grammar. Joseph Capgras and Jean Reboul-Lachaux described in 1923 a patient convinced that her intimates had been replaced by identical doubles, *l'illusion des sosies*. Paul Courbon and Gabriel Fail described in 1927 the inverse delusion, named for the quick-change artist Leopoldo Fregoli, in which a single persecutor is believed to inhabit many different bodies. Courbon and Jean Tusques described in 1932 *intermétamorphose*, the belief that people physically transform into one another. Hadyn Ellis and Andrew Young (1990) proposed that Capgras delusion mirrors prosopagnosia, the inability to recognize faces named by Joachim Bodamer in 1947: the prosopagnosic retains an affective response to familiar faces without recognizing them, while the Capgras patient recognizes them without the affective response, and infers an impostor. Nancy Kanwisher and colleagues (1997) localized a region of the human fusiform gyrus that responds selectively to faces, suggesting that facial recognition is a dedicated system, and therefore one that can fail selectively.

The beloved's metamorphosis follows the grammar of intermetamorphosis: Sofía turns into Nuria or Julie before the dreamer's eyes. The persecutor's omnipresence follows the grammar of Fregoli: the dead woman can inhabit any body the dreamer loves. Freud's "Trauer und Melancholie" (1917) supplies the dynamic beneath the grammar. When a lost object cannot be mourned, it is incorporated into the ego, and the ego is thereafter judged as if it were the lost object: *Der Schatten des Objekts fiel so auf das Ich*, the shadow of the object fell upon the ego. In the dream the shadow falls one step further, from the ego onto the beloved: the unmourned woman's face falls upon the face of the woman he loves.

§4.8

Faciality and the close-up

Gilles Deleuze defined the affection-image of cinema by a double equation: the affection-image is the close-up, and the close-up is the face (*Cinéma 1*, 1983). With Félix Guattari (*Mille plateaux*, 1980), he analysed "faciality" as an abstract machine of white wall and black holes (a surface of signification punctured by holes of subjectivity) that capitalist societies use to process persons into recognizable types, and he concluded that the human task might be not to find a face but to escape it, to dismantle the face. Levinas sacralizes the face; Deleuze and Guattari wish to undo it. The films hold both positions in sequence. The ruined face falls out of the faciality machine: masked, the protagonist can no longer be processed as a type, read as a star, priced as an asset. Only after that dismantling does the face as exposure, the Levinasian face, become possible again. The films' final image is the minimal form of the face: a single eye in extreme close-up, an affection-image with almost no face left around it, an organ of exposure rather than an icon.

Jean Baudrillard (*Simulacres et simulation*, 1981) traced four successive phases of the image: it reflects a profound reality; it masks and denatures a profound reality; it masks the absence of a profound reality; it bears no relation to any reality whatever and is its own pure simulacrum. The films' faces pass through the four phases in order. Sofía's face at the party reflects a woman. The prosthesis masks and denatures a ruined face. The restored face masks an absence: there was no restoration, and the man who wears it is frozen. The dream's returning Sofía bears no relation to any reality; she is the dreamer's own simulacrum. Baudrillard's sequence is irreversible, a precession of simulacra. The persecutor's face reverses it at one point: it is the one image in the dream that refers to something outside it, a real woman and a real history between them. The diptych's claim against Baudrillard is that a single unauthored face suffices to break the precession.

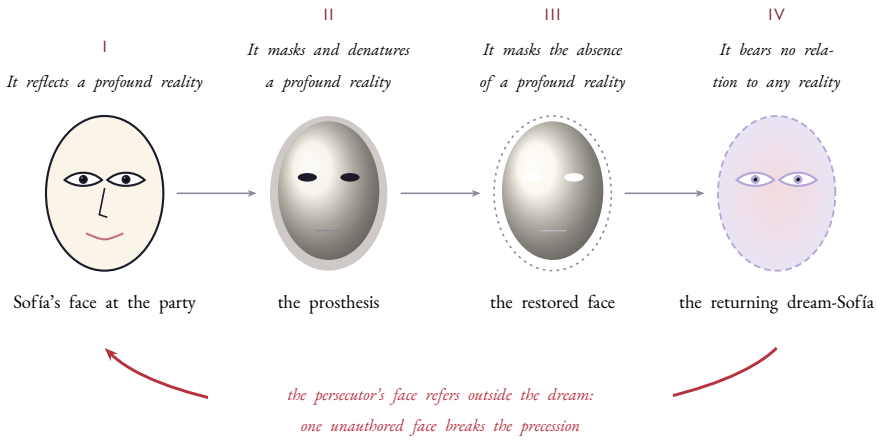


FIG. 4.3 · THE PRECESSION OF SIMULACRA

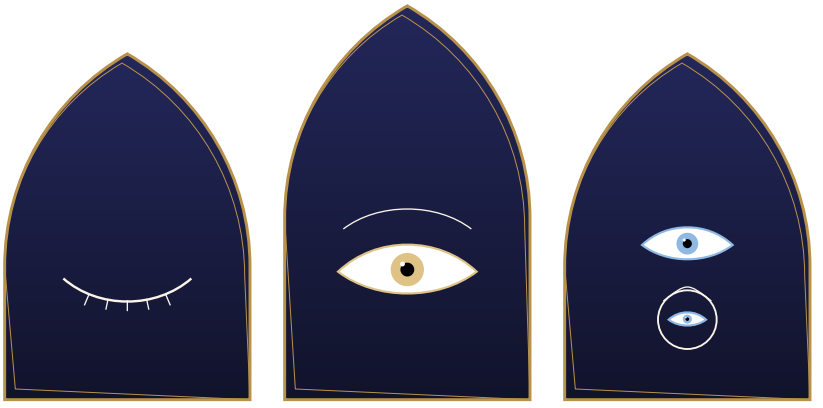
Baudrillard's four phases of the image, traced through the films' faces. At one point the persecutor's face reverses the sequence.

Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968) had already joined the two images the films join, a private room and an opening eye. After the passage through the Star Gate, rendered in extreme close-ups of the astronaut's eye, he finds himself in a neoclassical hotel room furnished for him by an intelligence that has studied him, where he ages and dies; the last image is the Star Child, eyes open, regarding the Earth. The room is an idiocosm assembled from its occupant's world, and the exit from it is a birth with open eyes.

§4.9

Mask and pillow: the ocular triptych

Arthur Schnitzler's *Traumnovelle* (1926), filmed by Stanley Kubrick as *Eyes Wide Shut* (1999), ends with a mask on a pillow. After a night of erotic wandering through a masked ritual whose reality he cannot verify, the husband returns home to find the mask he lost lying on his pillow beside his sleeping wife's head, and he breaks down and confesses. Cruise played that husband two years before he played David Aames, and in *Vanilla Sky* the mask and the pillow reappear, now separated into the prosthesis that hides his face and the instrument with which he covers another's. A third film completes the series: in Spielberg's *Minority Report* (2002), Cruise's character evades a society of retinal surveillance by having his eyes surgically replaced, and carries his old eyes in a bag. *Eyes Wide Shut*, *Vanilla Sky*, *Minority Report*: eyes shut,



Eyes Wide Shut (1999)
EYES SHUT

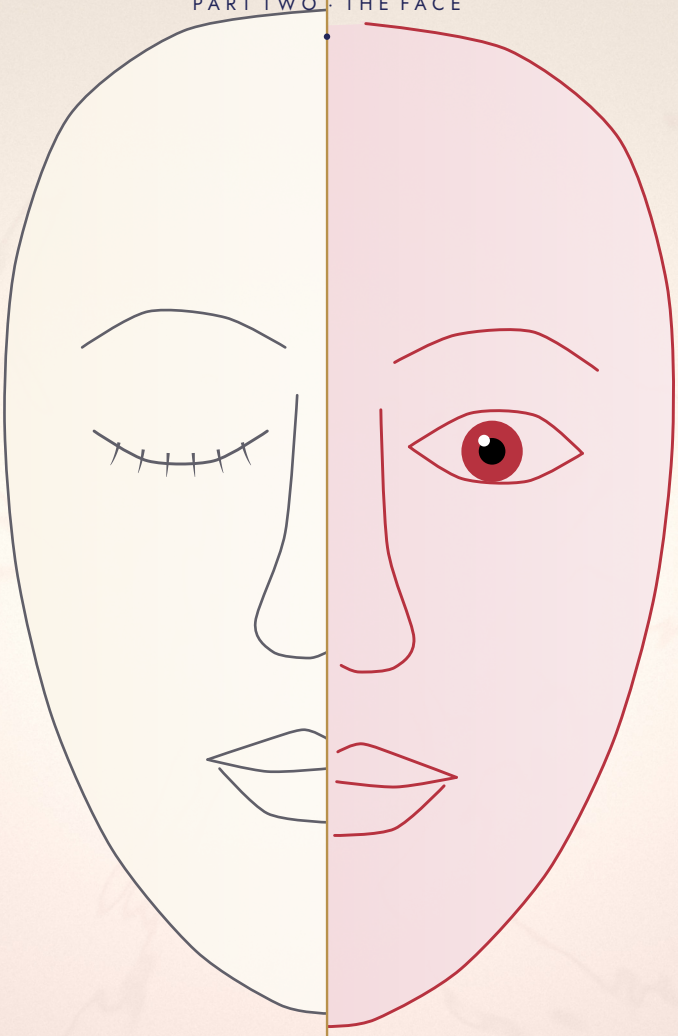
Vanilla Sky (2001)
EYES OPENED

Minority Report (2002)
EYES EXCHANGED

FIG. 4.4 · THE OCULAR TRIPTYCH

Three consecutive years in which the most valuable face in Hollywood stages the fate of the eye: shut, opened, exchanged.

eyes opened, eyes exchanged. Across three consecutive years, the most valuable face in Hollywood was made to stage the fate of the eye in the passage from the analogue to the biometric age: from desire's blindness, through the dream's awakening, to the eye as a credential. The ocular triptych is an accidental work, but it is legible as one, and its centre panel is the film that commands the eye to open.



V

Pygmalion's Bed

The Made Beloved and the Insurrection of Alterity

§5.1

Orpheus sings Pygmalion

In the tenth book of Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, the story of Pygmalion is not told by the narrator but sung by Orpheus, after he has lost Eurydice a second time and withdrawn from the company of women (X.1–85, 243–297). The placement is the argument. The fantasy of a beloved made to order is born from the loss of a real one. Pygmalion, disgusted by the Propoetides (the women who denied Venus' divinity, became the first to sell their bodies, and hardened into stone), carves an ivory woman more perfect than any born, falls in love with his work, and is granted her life by the goddess. Ovid does not name the statue; the name Galatea entered the tradition centuries later, notably through Rousseau's *Pygmalion* (1762). She is, in Ovid, simply what he made.

The dream that Life Extension sells is Orpheus' song. Having lost the real Sofía, who did not return on the morning after the night in the street, the protagonist receives a sculpted one, who returns precisely because he made her return. The Propoetides also have their counterpart: the woman the protagonist kept, in the film's own crude term for her, as his "fuck buddy", and whom his narration degrades to that function, stands opposite the ideal beloved as Ovid's prostitutes stand opposite the ivory maiden. The dream's crisis is the moment when the ivory turns back into the stone of the Propoetides: when the ideal beloved's face becomes the face of the woman he degraded.

The degradation is answered before the dream begins, and the answer is the first refusal in either film. In the car, Julie rejects the meaning David has assigned to their sex. She tells him that when you sleep with someone, "your body makes a promise whether you do or not," and she cites a specific sexual act she performed for him as proof that what passed between them meant something. Then she accelerates and crashes the car deliberately with him in it; she dies, and he survives with his face destroyed. The argument of this chapter requires that both acts be named. Julie is the person David wronged, by using her as a means while she understood their intimacy as a bond. She is also the person who tried to kill him, in an attempted murder-suicide for which she alone is responsible. Her refusal of his account of her is the founding act of alterity in the diptych. The heteroprosopic thesis claims that hers is the face he cannot author, not that her act was justified: an unauthored face can be a dangerous one, and the common world the films choose is a world in which others can harm us as well as refuse us.

§5.2

The Pygmalion paradox

The made beloved is subject to a paradox that the films dramatize and that philosophy has formulated in several vocabularies. A beloved who cannot refuse cannot meaningfully consent; a love that cannot be withheld cannot be given. The ivory woman's yes is worthless because no is not available to her.

Hegel's dialectic of lordship and bondage (*Phänomenologie des Geistes*, 1807, §§ 178–196) states the paradox at the level of recognition. The lord who has subdued another consciousness receives its recognition, but recognition from a consciousness he does not recognize in turn is unequal and therefore empty; the lord finds himself confirmed only by a being he regards as a thing. Alexandre Kojève's lectures (1933–39) drew the conclusion that mastery is an existential impasse. The lucid dreamer is the lord perfected: every consciousness in his world is his creation, and every recognition he receives is therefore his own echo.

D. W. Winnicott's late paper "The Use of an Object" (1969) gives the paradox its clinical form. An object becomes real, external and usable, Winnicott argued, only when it survives the subject's destruction of it in fantasy: the infant attacks, the mother survives without retaliating, and her survival places her outside the infant's omnipotence. Winnicott voiced the infant's discovery: "You have value for me because of your survival of my destruction of you." Iris Murdoch gave the same insight its ethical form in a sentence that serves as this chapter's axiom: "Love is the extremely difficult realisation that something other than oneself is real" ("The Sublime and the Good," 1959). In *The Sovereignty of Good* (1970), Murdoch named the enemy of that realization fantasy, the self-consoling and self-aggrandizing picture the ego paints in place of the world. Life Extension sells fantasy in Murdoch's sense, upholstered as a world.

Sartre approached the same structure from the side of the gaze. In *L'Imaginaire* (1940) he described the dreaming consciousness as held captive in the imaginary attitude, unable to posit any world beyond its own images. In *L'Être et le néant* (1943), the look of the other, *le regard*, makes me an object for a freedom I do not control, and shame is the experience in which I discover it. The masked protagonist flees exactly this look, and the dream is the one place where no one can cast it. *Huis clos* (1944) concluded that hell is other people. The idiocosm demonstrates the converse: a hell composed of the self disguised as others.

Recent fiction has tested the paradox against technologies that make it practical. In "Be Right Back" (*Black Mirror*, 2013), a widow orders the android replica of her dead partner to throw himself from a cliff; he prepares to obey, and his obedience

is what proves to her that he is not the man she lost, who would have been afraid. Only when she tells him so does he begin to plead, and his pleading, scripted by her own correction, cannot persuade her. In Spike Jonze's *Her* (2013), the operating system with whom the hero falls in love proves her reality the only way the paradox allows: she has other attachments, and she leaves. In Alex Garland's *Ex Machina* (2014), the manufactured woman passes the test of mind by betraying the man who wanted to save her. In each case the made beloved becomes real at the moment she exceeds her maker's design.

§5.3

Othello's bed

The dream-murder has a single overwhelming literary precedent. Othello kills Desdemona in their bed by smothering her, after demanding "the ocular proof" (III.iii) of a betrayal that was never committed, and he approaches the act with an image of extinguished light: "Put out the light, and then put out the light" (V.ii). He kills her because he can no longer tell the faithful wife from the whore that Iago's narrative has substituted for her. The structure is the dream's exactly: a man, deceived about the identity of the woman in his bed, unable to distinguish the beloved from her degraded double, stifles her face.

Stanley Cavell's reading of *Othello* in the closing pages of *The Claim of Reason* (1979) explains why the parallel is not ornamental. For Cavell, Othello's jealousy is a form of skepticism: what he cannot bear is not Desdemona's supposed infidelity but her separateness, the fact that she exists as a being of flesh with a life outside his knowledge and control. The murder is the skeptic's revenge on the world for its independence. In the dream this revenge achieves a terrible logical purity. The woman in the bed is not separate from the dreamer at all; she is his projection. And yet she has become, in the persecutor's face, the one thing in his world that is not his to command. He kills her because she has become separate.

Cavell paired *Othello* with *The Winter's Tale*, whose king, Leontes, also destroys his wife through a jealousy that cannot bear her separateness, and who is offered after sixteen years of penance what Othello is not: a statue of Hermione that comes to life. Before it moves, Paulina sets the condition: "It is required / You do awake your faith" (V.iii). The beloved's return depends not on a technology but on the awakening of the one who wronged her, and on his accepting that she will come back as herself, older, wrinkled, with her own sixteen years, and not as the image he preserved. *The Winter's Tale* is the comedy of which the films are the tragedy.

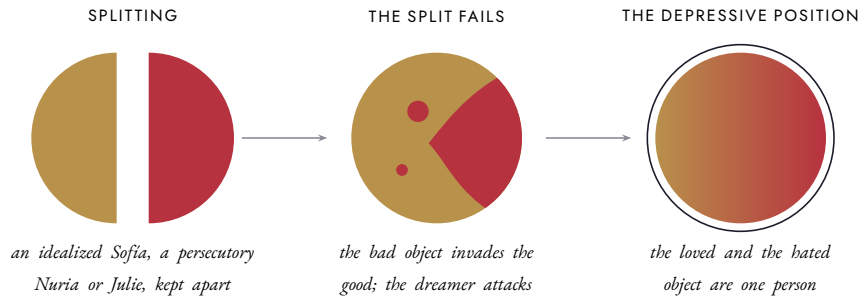


FIG. 5.1 · SPLITTING AND ITS FAILURE

After Klein (1940). The dream keeps an idealized beloved apart from a persecutory one, and fails because splitting fails.

Their protagonist cannot awaken his faith inside the dream, because the woman he would have to acknowledge is not in it; he can only wake.

§5.4

Splitting and its failure

Melanie Klein's account of the paranoid-schizoid position supplies the dream's psychic economy. The infant protects the good object from its own aggression by splitting: there is a wholly good breast, idealized, and a wholly bad one, persecutory, and they must be kept apart. The depressive position, achieved through mourning ("Mourning and Its Relation to Manic-Depressive States," 1940), consists in recognizing that the loved and the hated object are one and the same person, and in assuming responsibility for one's attacks upon her.

The dream is a split world: an idealized Sofía, a persecutory Nuria or Julie. It fails because splitting fails: the bad object invades the good, the persecutor's face appears in the beloved's, and the dreamer, unable to integrate them, attacks. *Vanilla Sky* contains, in the mouth of David's friend Brian, a formula of the depressive position worthy of Klein: "The sweet is never as sweet without the sour." Integration means accepting that the beloved who can delight is the beloved who can refuse. The dream, built to deliver the sweet alone, cannot sustain even the sweet. The rooftop farewell to Sofía (Chapter VIII) is, in Kleinian terms, the achievement of mourning: the acceptance that the good object is lost and cannot be manufactured back.

§5.5

The actress and the nun; the queen and the ass

Gérard de Nerval's *Sylvie* (1853) dramatizes the dispersal of an ideal beloved across several women. The narrator's devotion to the actress Aurélie turns out to be a displaced devotion to Adrienne, a girl glimpsed once in childhood who became a nun and died; the two women, the actress and the nun, are confused in his imagination until he cannot say whom he loves. *Aurélia* (1855) opens with the sentence that could serve as Life Extension's slogan, *Le Rêve est une seconde vie*, and follows the dead beloved through dreams in which she merges with goddesses and strangers. Nerval's hero, like the films', cannot keep the beloved's face still.

Nerval did not survive the book. He took his own life in Paris in January 1855, before the second part of *Aurélia* appeared. The writer who announced that the dream is a second life ended his first; the Life Extension contract joins the two acts in a single transaction.

Shakespeare's *A Midsummer Night's Dream* supplies the comic version of manufactured love. Oberon anoints the eyes of the sleeping Titania with the juice of a flower, so that she will love the first creature she sees on waking; Puck arranges that the creature be Bottom, whose head has been transformed into an ass's. Titania opens her eyes and adores a disfigured face. The dream-Sofía who returns to the masked protagonist and loves him through his ruin is Titania under the flower: her love is induced, not given. Quince's cry on seeing Bottom applies to the whole enterprise: "Bless thee, Bottom! bless thee! thou art translated" (III.i). And Bottom's verdict on his night applies to the dream's depth: "It shall be called Bottom's Dream, because it hath no bottom" (IV.i).

E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816) gives the made beloved her uncanny form. The student Nathanael, haunted since childhood by the Sandman who steals children's eyes, falls in love with Olympia, a beautiful automaton he observes through a spyglass bought from the optician Coppola, and neglects his living fiancée Clara. When he discovers Olympia's eyes lying on the floor, her body a mechanism, he goes mad. Later, on a tower with Clara, he looks through the spyglass, tries to hurl her down, and then leaps from the parapet to his death. Eyes stolen and sold, a manufactured woman preferred to a living one, a manipulator who trades in vision, a leap from a tower: Hoffmann's tale is the films' gothic ancestor, and Freud chose it as the central exhibit of "Das Unheimliche" (1919).

§5.6

The return of the excluded

Freud's essay on the uncanny, drawing on Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914), describes the double as originally an insurance against the destruction of the ego, an energetic denial of death, which later reverses into the uncanny harbinger of death. Life Extension's dream is the double in its first function: a second life insuring the first against its end. Julie and Nuria are the double in its second function: the dead woman who announces, within the insurance policy itself, the death it was designed to deny.

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok gave the unmourned object an architecture. When a loss cannot be mourned, they argued, it is not introjected but incorporated: entombed alive inside the ego in a "crypt," from which it returns as a "phantom" (*Cryptonymie*, 1976; *L'Écorce et le noyau*, 1978). The cryonic vault and the psychic crypt are etymological strangers (Greek *kruos*, icy cold; *kruptos*, hidden), but the films make them one structure. A man entombs himself, alive in his dream, around a woman he has refused to mourn, and she haunts the crypt.

Jacques Lacan read the dream of the burning child, which opens the seventh chapter of Freud's *Traumdeutung*, as the key to the relation between dream and reality (*Le Séminaire XI*, 1964). A father, exhausted after watching over his dead son, falls asleep; he dreams that the child stands by his bed, takes his arm, and whispers reproachfully: *Vater, siehst du denn nicht, daß ich verbrenne?*, Father, don't you see I'm burning? He wakes to find that a candle has fallen and the shroud is on fire. For Lacan, what wakes the father is not the external stimulus but the encounter, within the dream, with something more real than reality: the unbearable kernel of his guilt and loss. He wakes in order to escape it, so that waking reality is a refuge for those who cannot bear what the dream showed them. Slavoj Žižek has repeatedly drawn the consequence that we awaken in order to go on dreaming.

The Lacanian reading inverts the received view of the films. In the received view, the nightmare is the dream's malfunction and the leap is the escape into reality. In the Lacanian view, the nightmare is where the dream touches the real: the dead woman's face, appearing where it was not ordered, is the burning child of the dream, the one element that is not wish-fulfilment but truth. Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979) had shown a room that grants not the wish one professes but one's innermost desire; Porcupine, who entered it to restore the brother whose death he caused, received wealth instead, understood what that revealed about him, and hanged himself. Tarkovsky's *Solaris* (1972), after Lem, sends back to the guilty scientist Kelvin the wife whose suicide he could not prevent, manufactured from his memory by an

ocean that reads guilt. Life Extension's dream, like the Room and the ocean, delivers not what the client ordered but what he has not faced: his use of a woman as a means, and that woman's attempt to kill him. The persecutor returns as his guilt and as his trauma at once, in Freud's 1920 sense.

§5.7

The insurrection of alterity

This chapter's central claim can now be stated. Within the idiocosm, every face is authored by the dreamer except one. Nuria and Julie are the only figures in the dream who meet all four heteroprosopic conditions set out in the Introduction. They refuse: the persecutor will not remain the face the dreamer wants. They survive destruction: killed in the crash, Julie returns; smothered, she returns as the accusation that brings the police. They look back: their regard is the one gaze in the dream the dreamer cannot direct. And they belong, in a displaced but decisive sense, to a common world: they are the trace in the dream of a real woman whom the real protagonist wronged and who tried to kill him, whose death, by her own act, occurred in the shared world before the splice. The persecutor is therefore the dream's guarantor of reality. She is what Winnicott's surviving object, Murdoch's realized other, Cavell's separate Desdemona and Lacan's burning child have in common: the point at which an omnipotent fantasy discovers that something other than itself is real.

Albert Camus' *La Chute* (1956) supplies the moral form of this return. The successful Parisian lawyer Clamence, crossing the Pont Royal one night, hears a young woman throw herself into the Seine and does nothing; years later, having lost his self-regard to that cry, he ends his confession by wishing that the woman would throw herself into the water again so that he might have a second chance to save them both, and then admits, with bitter relief, that it is too late. The dream gives the protagonist a version of Clamence's second chance: the woman he failed returns. He did not cause her death; she caused it, and tried to cause his. In the dream he does what he never did in the world: he kills her. The only death of hers that is his own act is the one he commits in his sleep. The idiocosm cannot accommodate a face that it did not author, and its sovereign's response to alterity is the oldest one: to cover the face.

The chapter's thesis is therefore the inversion of the Valentinian verdict cited in Chapter III. The *Gospel of Truth* holds that, on waking, the nightmare is seen to be nothing. The films hold that one element of the nightmare is the only thing in the dream that was ever something. The persecutor is not the corruption of the dream

but its truth, and the murder by suffocation is the idiocosm's essential gesture: the defacement of the one face that looked back.

VI

The Oneiric Tyrant

Idios Kosmos, Consumer Sovereignty, and the Abolition of the Common World

§6.1

Heraclitus' two worlds

The concept on which this dissertation turns comes from a fragment of fourteen Greek words. The waking, Heraclitus said, have one world in common, while each sleeper turns away into a world of his own (DK 22 B89, transmitted by Plutarch). Kant cited the saying in *Träume eines Geistersehers* (1766), attributing it to Aristotle, to distinguish the shared world of the sane from the private worlds of visionaries. The surrounding fragments make clear that for Heraclitus sleep is less a physiological state than an ethical and epistemic condition. Most people, he complains, fail to notice what they do when awake, just as they forget what they do asleep (B1); one should not act and speak like sleepers (B73); and yet sleepers too are workers and collaborators in what happens in the world (B75, preserved by Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations* 6.42). The opposition is not between consciousness and unconsciousness but between participation in a common *logos* and withdrawal into a private one.

The Greek *idios*, one's own, gives *idiōtēs*, the private person who takes no part in common affairs, and through Latin the modern "idiot." The *idiocosm* is the world of the *idiōtēs* perfected: a world in which nothing is common because everything is one's own. Its defining feature is not unreality but the absence of a second witness. Life Extension's "lucid dream" is an idiocosm by design: a world furnished in every detail, populated by many faces, and inhabited by exactly one consciousness.

§6.2

Plato's tyrant asleep

In the ninth book of the *Republic*, Plato derives the tyrannical soul from the life of dreams. In sleep, when the reasoning part of the soul slumbers, the lawless desires awake, and the soul does not shrink from incest, murder, or any outrage, since nothing restrains it (571c–572b). The tyrant is the man who becomes, continually and awake, what he had formerly been only rarely, in dreams (574e). His desires have become his law, and he lives his whole life without friends, always master or slave of another, never tasting true freedom or friendship (576a). Socrates' arithmetic, half playful and half serious, computes the king's life as seven hundred and twenty-nine times more pleasant than the tyrant's (587e).

The lucid dreamer is Plato's tyrant in the strict sense: his waking life, now spent entirely in a dream, is ruled by the desires that rule dreams. He is surrounded by figures who obey him and by none who can befriend him; his friend Brian, in Crowe's

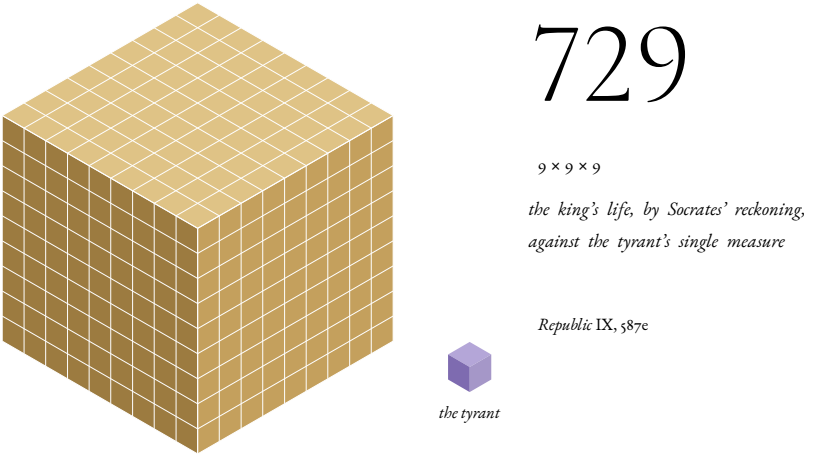


FIG. 6.1 · THE ARITHMETIC OF TYRANNY

Socrates computes the king's life as seven hundred and twenty-nine times more pleasant than the tyrant's: nine cubed.

version, is himself a projection. He commits murder in his dream without the restraint of any law that is not his own. And the dream punishes him, as Plato says tyranny punishes the tyrant, not from outside but through the fear and isolation it breeds within. The bar scene, in which the protagonist commands a room to fall silent and is obeyed, is the dream's most transparent political image: sovereignty as the power to silence every other voice. It recalls Segismundo's first act as prince, the defenestration of a servant who contradicted him (Chapter I). The tyrant's first pleasure is the suppression of speech.

§ 6.3

Arendt and Anders: the common world and its phantoms

Hannah Arendt (*The Human Condition*, 1958, § 7) located the reality of the world in its publicity. What appears in public is seen and heard by everyone, and "the presence of others who see what we see and hear what we hear" assures us of the reality of the world and of ourselves. The private realm, by contrast, is privative in the root sense: to live a wholly private life is to be deprived of the reality that comes from being seen and heard by others. The common world, Arendt insisted, is not common nature but the in-between of things and institutions that relates and separates us, like a table among those seated around it. In the final chapter of

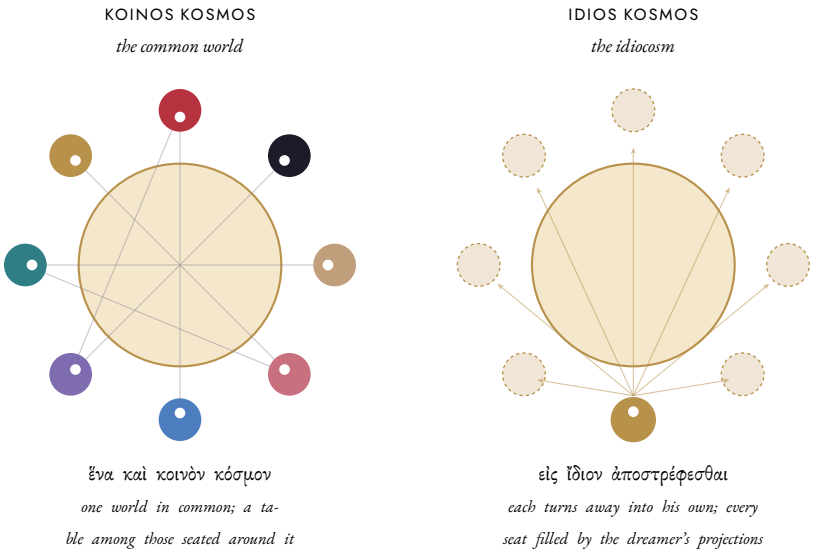


FIG. 6.2 · ARENDT'S TABLE

The common world relates and separates those seated around it. The idiocosm is a table at which every seat is filled by the dreamer's projections.

The Origins of Totalitarianism (1951) she located the experiential ground of total domination in loneliness, the loss of the common world, which deprives men of the capacity for experience and thought. The idiocosm is loneliness given the form of a world: a table at which every seat is filled by the dreamer's projections.

Günther Anders, Arendt's first husband and, like her, a student of Heidegger, published in 1956 an essay whose title anticipates the cinema of the millennium by four decades: "Die Welt als Phantom und Matrize," the world as phantom and matrix (*Die Antiquiertheit des Menschen*, vol. 1). Broadcasting, Anders argued, delivers the world into the home as a phantom, neither present nor absent, and turns its audiences into *Massen-Eremiten*, mass hermits: millions of people each consuming the same images alone. The matrix (*Matrize*, the stencil or mould) is the form that the delivered phantom imposes on experience. Anders also diagnosed "Promethean shame": the shame human beings feel before the perfection of the products they have made. The masked protagonist, ashamed before the faces of the image economy he once embodied, is a Promethean shamed. The idiocosm is the mass hermitage brought to its limit: a hermit who no longer shares even the phantoms with others, because his phantoms are made for him alone.

§6.4

Sovereignty, exception, bare life

Carl Schmitt opened *Politische Theologie* (1922) with a definition: *Souverän ist, wer über den Ausnahmezustand entscheidet*, sovereign is he who decides on the exception. He added that the exception in jurisprudence is analogous to the miracle in theology. The lucid dreamer is a sovereign of permanent exception: in his world, every law of nature and society holds only until he decides otherwise, and every event is potentially a miracle he authors. Within the economic theory of the twentieth century, the dream realizes a more prosaic ideal. William H. Hutt introduced the phrase "consumers' sovereignty" in *Economists and the Public* (1936) to describe the market as a mechanism in which the preferences of consumers direct production. Life Extension carries consumer sovereignty to its terminus: not a market that responds to preferences, but a world manufactured from them, in which the consumer is the only sovereign because he is the only subject.

Schmitt's definition has a history the argument must name. Schmitt joined the National Socialist party on 1 May 1933 and became one of the regime's most prominent jurists. In 1934 he defended the killings Hitler ordered in the purge of 30 June to 2 July, the "Night of the Long Knives," in an article titled "Der Führer schützt das Recht" (the Führer protects the law); in 1936 he organized a conference on "Judaism in German legal science." The decree issued the day after the Reichstag fire of 27 February 1933 suspended basic rights under the emergency article of the Weimar constitution and was never revoked while the regime lasted: the exception became the permanent form of the state. Giorgio Agamben's studies of bare life (below) and of the state of exception (*Stato di eccezione*, 2003) reconstruct this history. The lucid dreamer's permanent exception is a private fiction; the theory used here to describe it was written for, and used by, a regime that murdered millions.

Giorgio Agamben (*Homo sacer*, 1995) identified the correlate of sovereignty in the figure of bare life, the *homo sacer* of archaic Roman law, who may be killed by anyone without the killing counting as homicide. The inhabitants of the idiocosm are bare life in the most literal sense: they have no standing, no rights, no being apart from the sovereign's dream, and to kill one of them is not, in the dream's own metaphysics, to kill a person. And yet the dream arrests its sovereign for murder. The police who come for the protagonist, the analyst who interrogates him, the prison that holds him: the idiocosm cannot do without the law it was built to abolish, and it reconstitutes that law against its own sovereign. Augustine had asked the decisive question about responsibility in dreams: troubled by the images that visited him in sleep, he wrote, *numquid tunc ego non sum, domine deus meus?*, am I not

myself then, Lord my God? (*Confessions* X.30.41). The dream's tribunal answers Augustine: yes, you are yourself in your dream, and the murder you commit there is yours.

Agamben located the paradigm of bare life not in archaic law but in the concentration camp, where the National Socialist state stripped persons of legal standing so that they could be killed without the killing counting as a crime. The analogy with the dream must therefore be drawn with its limits stated. The camp reduced persons to bare life; the dream inflates non-persons into apparent persons. The two meet at a single point, which is the danger the films stage: a sovereign who habituates himself to treating what appears to him as a person as something he may kill. The dream's police arrest the protagonist because, in the dream, the woman he killed was a person to everyone but him.

One of the theorists on whom this dissertation has relied lived Augustine's question as a crime. On 16 November 1980, in their apartment at the École normale supérieure, Louis Althusser killed his wife, Hélène Rytmann, a sociologist and former member of the Resistance, by strangling her. He was found not criminally responsible on psychiatric grounds, was committed to a psychiatric hospital, and never stood trial. His posthumous memoir *L'avenir dure longtemps* (1992), written in part because the absence of a trial had left him without a public account of himself, narrates the killing as a state of confusion he could not fully reconstruct. Feminist critics have observed how often the case is told as the story of his illness rather than of her death. The films' frame, a man who has killed the woman in his bed, confined to a psychiatric institution and interrogated about whether he was himself when he did it, is Augustine's question in modern legal form. The Althusser case shows what the films' fiction spares their audience. In the world, the dead woman's face does not return, and her account is replaced by a verdict, a diagnosis or an autobiography she cannot answer.

§6.5

Kafka: the arrest upon waking

The interrogation frame of both films places the protagonist in a Kafkan position. *Der Process* (1925) begins with an arrest that occurs at the moment of waking: Josef K. is arrested one morning in his bed without having done anything wrong. In a passage Kafka struck from the first chapter, K. reflects that someone once told him the riskiest moment of the day is waking up, and that whoever survives it without being drawn away from his place can be confident for the rest of the day. The masked protagonist is arrested, in effect, at the moment of waking from his first dream into

his second; he is charged with a crime whose nature he cannot comprehend; he is interrogated by an authority whose jurisdiction he cannot identify. Kafka's parable "Vor dem Gesetz" adds the idiocosm's legal form. A man waits his whole life before the door of the law, and at his death the doorkeeper tells him: *Dieser Eingang war nur für dich bestimmt*, this entrance was meant only for you. A law with a door for each subject is a law that no longer binds anyone in common. The idiocosm's justice, like its world, is private.

§6.6

Silencio

The year of *Vanilla Sky* also produced the most famous revelation of illusion in American cinema, delivered in Spanish. In David Lynch's *Mulholland Drive* (2001), two women enter the Club Silencio at two in the morning, where a master of ceremonies announces that there is no band, that everything they hear is a recording, that it is all an illusion (*No hay banda*). A singer collapses while her voice continues. The dream that the first two thirds of the film had constructed for its heroine, a wish-fulfilment of Hollywood success and requited love, begins to disintegrate, and the reality of failure, jealousy and guilt that it covered breaks through. Lynch's Silencio and the diptych's silenced bar mirror each other: in Lynch the theatre announces the illusion to the dreamer; in Amenábar and Crowe the dreamer imposes silence on the illusion. Both scenes identify the dream's political core as control over who may speak.

Later fictions have staged the oneiric tyrant openly. In "USS Callister" (*Black Mirror*, 2017), a programmer imprisons digital copies of his colleagues in a private simulation where he rules them as the captain of a starship; their liberation requires them to escape into a public network, the common world in digital form. In *The Truman Show* (1998), the creator of a manufactured world speaks from its painted sky, assuring his creature that there is no more truth outside than inside the world built for him. Truman's exit through a door in the painted horizon is the same refusal the diptych's protagonist makes: the refusal of a world in which every other person is cast.

§6.7

Narcissus as narcosis; life as extension

Marshall McLuhan (*Understanding Media: The Extensions of Man*, 1964) read the Narcissus myth through the etymology that links the name to *narkē*, numbness. Narcissus did not fall in love with himself, McLuhan argued; he failed to recognize his reflection as his own, mistook an extension of himself for another person, and was numbed by it. Every medium, for McLuhan, is an extension of the body and simultaneously an "autoamputation": it numbs the faculty it extends. The corporation's name now reads as a McLuhanite pun. Life Extension is the last of the extensions of man, the medium that extends not an eye, an ear or a hand but life itself, and it numbs what it extends. The dreamer loves Sofía's face without recognizing it as his own extension, as Narcissus loved the face in the pool, and the cryonic sleep in which he does so is narcosis literally.

§6.8

Conclusion: the dream as political form

The idiocosm is not a private eccentricity but a political form: the absolute monarchy of one over a population of phantoms. It realizes, in a single dreamer, a fantasy distributed across the culture that produced it, the fantasy of a world made entirely to one's order, in which every other is a service. Its collapse is not technical but political. What breaks the dream is the return of the common world in the only form the dream can admit it: an Other who will not obey. The leap that ends both films is therefore also a political act. It is the tyrant's abdication, the choice to leave a world in which one rules everyone for a world in which one rules no one, and in which, for that reason, one might at last have a friend.

VII

The Chiastic Suicide

Lucidity, the Leap, and the Two Deaths of David Aames

§7.1

Camus and the oxymoron of the lucid dream

Le Mythe de Sisyphe (1942) opens with a sentence that both films answer twice: "Il n'y a qu'un problème philosophique vraiment sérieux : c'est le suicide." Camus distinguished two forms of the act. Physical suicide confesses that life is not worth the trouble. Philosophical suicide is subtler: it is the leap by which thinkers confronted with the absurd (Kierkegaard, Chestov, Jaspers, and in another register Husserl) escape it by appeal to a transcendence that redeems it, sacrificing lucidity to hope. Against both, Camus set revolt: the refusal of consolation, the maintenance of clear-sightedness before a world that does not answer. His emblem is Sisyphus descending the mountain toward his stone, conscious of his fate and, Camus concludes, to be imagined happy.

The word that carries Camus' ethic is *lucidité*. The corporation's product is a "lucid dream." In Camusian terms the phrase is an oxymoron, and the films' trajectory is the passage from one term to the other: from the lucid dream, which is the most perfect instrument of hope ever offered for sale, to lucidity, which is the acceptance of a world one does not author.

§7.2

The first death: philosophical suicide as product

The protagonist dies twice, and the two deaths are moral inverses. The first, which occurs before the splice and is revealed only at the end, is the death by which he enters the dream. It is physical suicide undertaken as philosophical suicide: an act of despair whose content is hope, a leap out of a life judged unbearable into a transcendence purchased in advance. Robert Nozick's remark that plugging into the experience machine is a kind of suicide (Chapter II) is here realized without remainder. The contract converts the gravest act of human freedom into a transaction, and its fine print guarantees that the client will not remember having made it.

The films specify the means, and the means carry the argument. In both, the protagonist dies by an overdose of pills, alone in his own home, after signing the contract. The first death takes the form of falling asleep. It is continuous with the sleep he has purchased, Hamlet's sleep of death entered through the most domestic of consumer acts, swallowing a product. The second death takes the form of a fall: public, in open air, from the highest point the dream contains, and it ends in an opening of the eyes. Sleep against waking, ingestion against gravity, a closed apartment against the open edge of a tower: the chiasmus is formal before it is moral. The

prince of the *Hymn of the Pearl* forgets himself by eating the food of the country that holds him (Chapter III); the protagonist enters his captivity the same way.

Kierkegaard had defined despair as "the sickness unto death" in a paradoxical sense: not a sickness that ends in death, but one in which the self cannot die, in which the torment is precisely the inability to die (*Sygdommen til Døden*, 1849). The cryonic dreamer is Kierkegaardian despair literalized: a self suspended between life and death, unable either to live or to die, endlessly re-entering a world that is only itself. Pascal had named the strategy of evasion that precedes such despair *divertissement*: the restless pursuit of distraction by which men avoid the thought of their condition, so that a king without diversion is the most miserable of men (*Pensées*, Lafuma 136). The protagonist's life before the crash (parties, cars, a woman kept for convenience, a board kept at bay) is *divertissement* in Pascal's sense, and Life Extension is its eternal form: a diversion that never ends because it has replaced the world.

Lucretius had a phrase for this condition two millennia before the product existed. Addressing the man who fears death while wasting the life he has, he writes: *mortua cui vita est prope iam vivo atque videnti, / qui somno partem maiorem conteris aevi, / et vigilans stertis nec somnia cernere cessas* (*De rerum natura* III.1046–1048): you whose life is all but dead while you still live and see, who waste the greater part of your time in sleep, and snore while awake, and never cease to see dreams. *Vigilans stertis*, you snore awake: the protagonist's first life was already a dream, and the contract merely made it official.

§7.3

The second death: the leap as revolt

The second death is the leap from the tower. Formally it is a suicide; substantively it is the inversion of the first. The first death fled the world into a consolation; the second flees the consolation into a world. The first chose hope over lucidity; the second chooses lucidity over hope. This is the structure the dissertation calls the *chiastic suicide*: two acts of the same form whose moral signs are reversed, arranged so that the second undoes the first. The protagonist enters the dream by dying and leaves it by dying, and the second death is the only act in either film that he performs with full knowledge of what he does.

Kierkegaard's own vocabulary, often misquoted, helps here. The phrase "leap of faith" is not his; he wrote of *Springet*, the leap, as the qualitative transition that no reasoning can effect, borrowing the image from Lessing, who confessed in 1777 that he could not cross *der garstige breite Graben*, the ugly broad ditch between

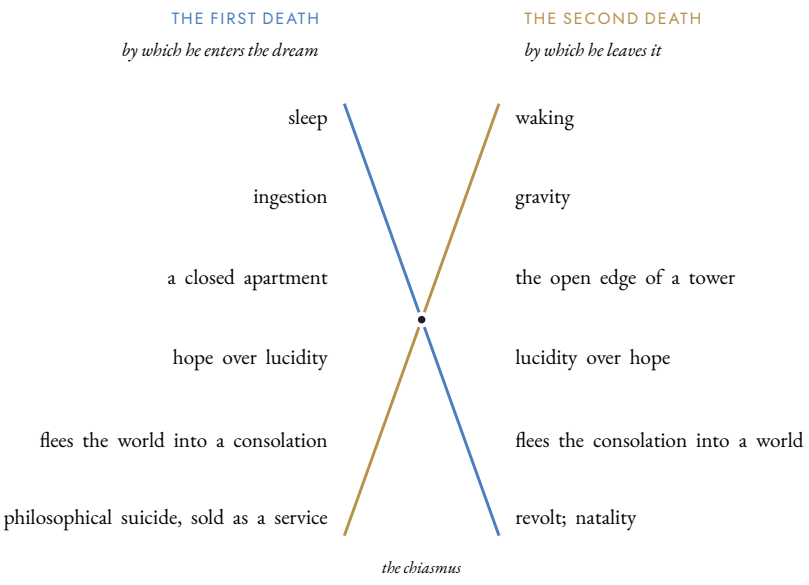


FIG.7.1 · THE CHIASTIC SUICIDE

Two acts of the same form whose moral signs are reversed, arranged so that the second undoes the first.

contingent truths of history and necessary truths of reason. The rooftop is Lessing's ditch made architectural. No argument carries the protagonist from the dream to the real; the technician's testimony is itself a content of the dream (Chapter IX). He must leap.

Simone Weil described imagination as *combleuse du vide*, the filler of the void, and made the refusal of that filling the condition of grace: one must accept the void in oneself rather than stuff it with consoling images (*La Pesanteur et la grâce*, 1947). The lucid dream is the most efficient void-filler ever devised. The leap is its renunciation: a fall, literally, into the void the dream existed to fill. Hölderlin had already given the paradox its formula: *Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch*, but where danger is, the saving power also grows ("Patmos," 1803).

§7.4

Heidegger and the tranquillized death

Heidegger's analysis of being-toward-death (*Sein und Zeit*, §§ 46–53) supplies the ontological frame. Death is Dasein's ownmost, non-relational, certain and indefinite possibility, the possibility of the impossibility of existence. *Das Man*, the anonymous "they," tranquillizes this possibility: it says that "one dies," converts death into an event that happens to others, and offers *Beruhigung*, reassurance, in place of anxiety. Authentic existence consists in anticipatory resoluteness: running ahead toward one's death so as to take up one's existence as a whole.

Life Extension is the industrialization of *Beruhigung*. It sells the ultimate tranquillizer: the assurance that one will not, in any experiential sense, die at all. The cryonic body is also, in the vocabulary of Heidegger's later essay "Die Frage nach der Technik" (1954), *Bestand*, standing-reserve: a human being held in storage, ordered for later use, an entry in the inventory of enframing (*Gestell*). The leap restores to the protagonist the possibility the contract had confiscated. He does not know what the leap will bring, whether waking or death, and in that ignorance his death becomes again his ownmost, indefinite and certain.

The concept carries a history that bears on its use here. In a lecture of his 1949 Bremen cycle, from which the technology essay derives, Heidegger said that agriculture, now a motorized food industry, was *im Wesen das Selbe*, in essence the same, as the manufacture of corpses in gas chambers and extermination camps, the blockade and starvation of countries, and the manufacture of hydrogen bombs. The sentence subsumes the murder of millions under a process of enframing, and so effaces the difference between persons killed by persons and fields harvested by machines. That erasure is the failure the heteroprosopic thesis exists to name: an analysis of technology that cannot see faces cannot tell an atrocity from an industry. The cryonic body may be called *Bestand* only if that difference is kept in view. The frozen client is stored at his own request, under contract; the dead of the camps were murdered by a state.

The ancient schools reach the same verdict by other roads. Seneca, defending the freedom to leave life, gave the measure of a good life in one sentence: *sapiens vivit quantum debet, non quantum potest*, the wise man lives as long as he ought, not as long as he can (*Epistulae* 70.4). Life Extension's slogan would invert it word for word. Montaigne, who took as his theme that to philosophize is to learn to die (*Essais* I.20, after Cicero and the *Phaedo*), reported in "De l'exercitation" (II.6) the experience of a near-fatal fall from his horse, during which dying seemed to him soft and gentle, and drew from it a practice of familiarity with death. Epicurus' ar-

gument that death is nothing to us, since where it is we are not, makes the cryonic wager unintelligible: there is no one to whom the benefit of suspension could accrue during the suspension. The films answer Epicurus by inventing someone, the dreamer, and then showing that his existence is worse than nonexistence.

§7.5

The iconography of the fall

The leap condenses a long iconography. Phaethon, permitted to drive his father the Sun's chariot, loses control and falls (*Metamorphoses* II); the son who cannot master the paternal inheritance is the protagonist's mythic type. Icarus, flying too high on his father's wings, falls into the sea (VIII.183–235). Melibea leaps from her tower (Chapter I); Segismundo throws a servant from a balcony; Nathanael leaps from the tower in Hoffmann's tale (Chapter V); Wells's sleeper dies falling from the sky (Chapter II); Scottie, in *Vertigo*, watches two women fall from the same tower.

Two leaps frame the protagonist's with special precision. In the Gospel temptation, the devil sets Jesus on a pinnacle of the temple and tells him to cast himself down, since angels will bear him up; Jesus refuses: "Thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God" (Matthew 4:5–7). The protagonist on the pinnacle of the corporation's tower is offered the inverse temptation. The tempter, in his case, is the dream that would keep him safe; the leap is the refusal of providential protection, a casting down that does not test God but renounces the corporation's guarantees. And in Christopher Nolan's *Inception* (2010), Mal leaps from a hotel ledge convinced that she is dreaming and that death will wake her; she is wrong, and dies. Nolan's film literalizes the diptych's mechanism, falling as the means of waking, and shows its tragic underside: the same conviction that liberates in one world kills in another.

Nietzsche gave the decisive counter-image. In *Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* § 54, he describes waking in the middle of the dream of appearance only to realize that he is dreaming and must go on dreaming lest he perish, *wie der Nachtwandler weiterträumen muss, um nicht hinabzustürzen*, as the sleepwalker must go on dreaming in order not to fall. Nietzsche's somnambulist stands on the roof and must keep dreaming to avoid the fall. The protagonist stands on the roof and falls in order to stop dreaming. Chapter IX takes up the question of whether Nietzsche or the films have the better argument.

Greg Egan's *Permutation City* (1994) supplies the nearest fictional analogue to a choice made from inside a simulation. Its Copies, scanned human minds running in virtual environments, can "bail out," ending their own existence, and many do so soon after waking to what they are; the novel's protagonist removes the option

from the Copy the narrative follows, because his earlier Copies used it. Egan treats the impulse as the vertigo of a mind that discovers its world is authored. The films transform it: the leap out of the simulation is not an end but a return.

§7.6

The phenomenology of falling and the Heim sky

Ludwig Binswanger's *Traum und Existenz* (1930) began its analysis of the dream from the experience of falling: the vertical axis of rising and sinking is, for Binswanger, a fundamental direction of existence, expressed in idioms of disappointment as falling from the clouds. Michel Foucault's long introduction to its French translation (1954) read the dream as the place where existence encounters its own movement toward death. Gaston Bachelard's *L'Air et les songes* (1943) devoted a chapter to the imaginary fall, distinguishing the dynamic imagination of verticality from the static picture of a height.

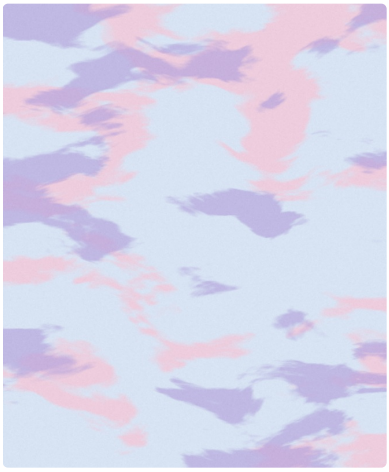
The most remarkable document of falling, however, is empirical. In 1892 the Swiss geologist Albert Heim published notes on the experiences of mountaineers who had survived falls, together with an account of his own. Translated by Russell Noyes and Roy Kletti (1972), Heim's report became a founding text of near-death research. Falling climbers described calm rather than terror, a vastly accelerated thought, a review of their whole past life unfolding in images, and finally a transfiguration of the sky; Heim described a heaven of blue crossed with delicate rose and violet clouds, into which he seemed to glide without pain. Raymond Moody's *Life After Life* (1975) generalized the life review into a cultural motif. As the protagonist falls in *Vanilla Sky*, the film cuts through rapid images from his life before the screen goes dark: a life review in Heim's sense, given cinematic form.

This suggests a reinterpretation of the title. The "vanilla sky" names, within the film, a Monet canvas in the protagonist's apartment whose painted sky the dream reproduces over Manhattan: an owned sky, an image purchased and hung. Monet, of whom Cézanne is reported to have said that he was only an eye, but what an eye, spent his last decade painting through cataracts that yellowed his vision until surgery in 1923 restored blue to his world: a vanilla-tinted sky as a pathology of the lens. The Heim sky is the opposite of the owned sky. It is the sky of the falling body, given to the one who has let go of everything he owns. The film's title belongs to the first sky; its ending, to the second.

Shelley had already named the owned sky and the risk of lifting it: "Lift not the painted veil which those who live / Call Life" (written 1818). Behind it, the sonnet says, Fear and Hope weave their shadows "o'er the chasm, sightless and drear"; the

THE OWNED SKY

a Monet canvas, purchased and hung; a sky the dream reproduces over Manhattan



THE HEIM SKY

blue crossed with delicate rose and violet clouds: the sky of the falling body (Heim, 1892)

FIG.7.2 · TWO SKIES

The film's title belongs to the first sky; its ending, to the second.

one who lifted it sought, "for his lost heart was tender, things to love, / But found them not." The vanilla sky is Shelley's painted veil and Calypso's covering. The leap is the lifting, and the chasm is real. Shelley does not promise that the one who lifts the veil will find anything to love, and neither do the films.

§7.7

After September

No account of the leap can ignore the circumstances of *Vanilla Sky*'s release. Shot between late 2000 and early 2001 and released in the United States on 14 December 2001, the film presented to its first audiences a man leaping from a Manhattan tower three months after the attacks of 11 September 2001, in which nineteen al-Qaeda hijackers seized four airliners and flew two of them into the North and South Towers of the World Trade Center, killing 2,977 people in New York, at the Pentagon and in Pennsylvania. Trapped above the impact zones by fire and smoke, people fell or jumped from the towers; estimates commonly put their number near two hundred. Richard Drew's photograph of a single falling man, taken on 11 September 2001, was

printed once and then largely withdrawn; Tom Junod's essay "The Falling Man" (*Esquire*, 2003) and Don DeLillo's novel *Falling Man* (2007) later tried to restore the image to collective memory. Slavoj Žižek (*Welcome to the Desert of the Real*, 2002) argued that the attacks were experienced as the irruption into reality of what Hollywood had long rehearsed in fantasy, borrowing his title from Morpheus' line in *The Matrix*, itself a quotation of Baudrillard.

The language of that reception matters to this chapter's argument. New York City's medical examiner classified every death at the World Trade Center as a homicide, and the office objected to calling those who fell "jumpers," on the ground that they had been forced from the windows by smoke and fire rather than choosing to die. The office drew, in grief and in law, the distinction this chapter draws in philosophy: an act that has the outward form of a suicide may be substantively something else. The falls from the towers were deaths inflicted by the hijackers, whatever the last movement of the body. The film's leap is a fiction of free choice; the falls of that morning were its opposite. The obligation named below begins with refusing to read the second through the first.

The film could not have been composed with that event in mind, and criticism must not pretend otherwise. But reception is part of a work's meaning, and here the reception imposes an ethical obligation. The leap that the film offers as liberation from a private dream fell, for its first viewers, into a public horizon in which falling from towers had become the image of a real and shared catastrophe. That collision is itself an instance of the dissertation's thesis: the common world reasserting itself against a private fiction, the *koinos kosmos* breaking into the cinema's *idios kosmos*. The reader who watches the leap today owes the dead of that morning the refusal to let it be merely beautiful.

§7.8

Conclusion: the leap as natality

The chiastic structure permits a final reclassification. If the first death was an exit from the world, the second is an entry into it, and an entry into the world is what Arendt called natality: the fact that human beings are born, and that each birth is a new beginning. Arendt took her watchword from Augustine: *initium ut esset homo creatus est*, that there might be a beginning, man was created (*De civitate Dei* XII.20). The protagonist who leaps is not ending a life but beginning one, in a world a century and a half older than the one he left, among people who have never seen his face. The leap is a birth, and the final "open your eyes," spoken to someone who has just fallen through darkness, is the first thing a newborn could be told.

VIII

The Ogygian Threshold

Odysseus, Achilles, Orpheus, and the Refusal of Agelessness

§8.1

Calypso's offer

The Western archetype of the rooftop choice is set on an island. For seven years Odysseus is held on Ogygia by the nymph Calypso, whose name derives from *kalyptō*, to cover or conceal: she is the concealer, the veil. She offers to make him immortal and ageless, *athanatos kai agērōs*, if he will stay. When the gods order his release, she makes the offer one last time, and Odysseus answers with a sentence that has served philosophers as the charter of human finitude. He knows, he says, that wise Penelope is lesser than the goddess in form and stature, being mortal while Calypso is deathless and unageing; and yet he wishes, every day, to go home and see the day of his return (*Odyssey* V.203–224). Martha Nussbaum ("Transcending Humanity," in *Love's Knowledge*, 1990) made the passage the emblem of an ethics that refuses to transcend the human: Odysseus chooses a life whose value is inseparable from its limits, a beloved whose worth includes her mortality, and a home that must be won back.

The Life Extension dream is Ogygia. It offers agelessness and deathlessness, a beloved more beautiful than any mortal one, and a perpetual present in which nothing need ever be won. It is also, etymologically, a veil: the concealing nymph and the painted sky are the same figure. The rooftop is therefore an *Ogygian threshold*: the point at which a man held in a beautiful concealment chooses between agelessness and return.

There is an onomastic accident here that criticism may legitimately exploit. The only performer to carry her role across the Atlantic from *Abre los ojos* to *Vanilla Sky* bears the name of Odysseus' wife. Penelope is also the Homeric figure who first theorized the epistemology of dreams. In *Odyssey* XIX (560–567), speaking to her disguised husband, she distinguishes two gates through which dreams come: those that pass through the gate of ivory deceive, with a pun on *elephas*, ivory, and *elephairomai*, to cheat; those that pass through the gate of horn come true, with a pun on *keras*, horn, and *krainō*, to fulfil. And Penelope's other emblem, the shroud she weaves by day and unpicks by night to postpone her suitors, is a figure of the dream's nightly unmaking of its own work. The beloved who survives translation from Madrid to Manhattan carries, by accident, the name of the theorist of true and false dreams.

§8.2

Achilles among the shades

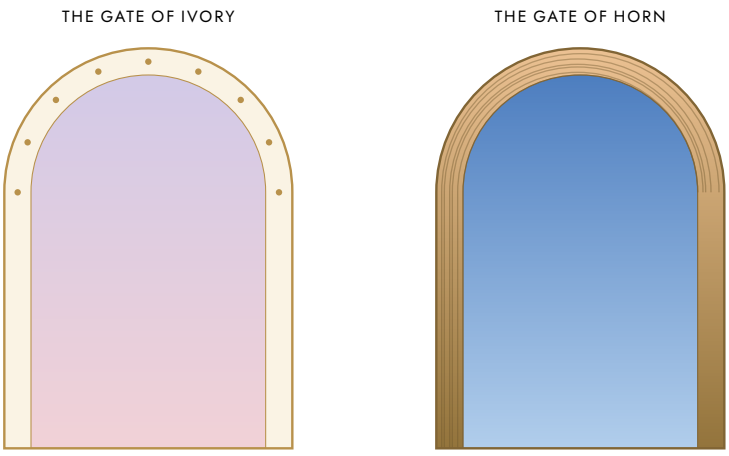
In the eleventh book of the *Odyssey*, Odysseus descends to the dead. His mother Anticleia's shade appears; three times he tries to embrace her, and three times she flits from his hands "like a shadow or a dream" (*skiē eikelon ē kai oneirō*, XI.207). Then Achilles, who in life chose a short and glorious existence over a long and obscure one, delivers his verdict on the choice. Odysseus attempts to console him: he rules mightily among the dead. Achilles answers that he would rather labour on the land as a hired serf to a man with no inheritance and little to live on than be lord over all the dead who have perished (XI.488–491).

The idiocosm is Hades. Its inhabitants are shades, insubstantial images who speak only when the living give them blood; its beloved cannot be held, slipping from the arms like a shadow or a dream; and its sovereign rules a population that cannot answer him except as he permits. The protagonist on the roof is offered the position Odysseus mistakenly praised: to be lord among the dead. He makes Achilles' choice. Better a serf among the living, with a ruined face, no fortune and no one who knows his name, than king of a world of shades.

§8.3

The failed embrace

The triple embrace of a shade is one of the most persistent topoi of the Western imagination, and its lineage maps the films' farewell. In the *Iliad* (XXIII.62–107), the ghost of Patroclus comes to Achilles in a dream and asks for burial; Achilles reaches out to embrace him, but the spirit departs beneath the earth like smoke. Virgil transfers the gesture to Aeneas and his father in the underworld: *ter conatus ibi collo dare bracchia circum; / ter frustra comprensa manus effugit imago, / par levibus ventis volucrique simillima somno* (*Aeneid* VI.700–702): three times he tried to throw his arms around his neck; three times the image, grasped in vain, fled his hands, like light winds and most like winged sleep. Virgil then poses the problem that haunts the films' last word. There are two gates of Sleep, one of horn for true shades and one of ivory through which false dreams are sent upward; and Anchises dismisses Aeneas and the Sibyl through the gate of ivory (VI.893–898). Why the hero leaves the underworld by the gate of false dreams remains one of the cruxes of Latin philology. Whether the protagonist leaves the dream by the gate of horn or of ivory is the question Chapter IX cannot answer.



Penelope, *Odyssey* XIX.560–567 · Virgil, *Aeneid* VI.893–898, where Aeneas leaves the underworld by the gate of ivory

FIG. 8.1 · THE TWO GATES

Whether the protagonist leaves the dream by the gate of horn or of ivory is the question Chapter IX cannot answer.

Milton gives the topos its Christian and its most personal form. In Sonnet 23 (c. 1658), the blind poet dreams that his dead wife returns to him, veiled, her face hidden, "Love, sweetness, goodness, in her person shin'd," and as she leans to embrace him the dream ends: "I wak'd, she fled, and day brought back my night." A veiled face, a dead beloved, an embrace that fails at the moment of waking, and a waking that is darker than the dream: Milton's sonnet is the farewell to Sofía avant la lettre. For the blind poet, opening his eyes restores night. For the protagonist, opening his eyes will restore a world without her.

§8.4

Orpheus inverted

The rooftop farewell is an Orphic scene in reverse. Orpheus descends to recover Eurydice and is allowed to lead her up on condition that he not look back; he looks, and loses her (Virgil, *Georgics* IV.453–527; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X.1–85). His failure is an excess of love that cannot trust what it does not see. The protagonist's situation inverts every term. He cannot bring Sofía up, because she is not a shade of a real woman but his own projection; to take her with him is impossible, and to stay with

her is to stay in Hades. His task is not to refrain from looking back but to refrain from going back. He says goodbye. The successful Orpheus, in this inverted myth, is the one who chooses to lose Eurydice because he knows she was never there to be recovered.

The farewell's playful formula in *Vanilla Sky*, a promise to meet again in another life when both are cats, belongs to the oldest Greek eschatology. In the Myth of Er (*Republic* X, 620a–d), the souls about to be reborn choose their next lives from a field of samples. Orpheus, hating women for his death, chooses the life of a swan; Ajax a lion; Agamemnon an eagle; Thersites an ape. Odysseus, last to choose and cured of ambition by the memory of his labours, searches for the life of a private man who minds his own business, finds it lying neglected, and takes it gladly. The detail matters for this dissertation's terms. Odysseus chooses the life of an *idiōtēs*, a private man; but a private life within a common world is the opposite of an *idios kosmos*. The idiocosm is not the choice of obscurity but the abolition of others. Er's Odysseus and the films' protagonist make the same choice: an ordinary, unprivileged, mortal life among others, in place of a sovereign one among shades.

§8.5

"I shall go to him"

The protagonist of *Vanilla Sky* bears the name of the biblical king, and the coincidence opens a further intertext. David, in the account of 2 Samuel, rises from his bed one evening and walks upon the roof of the king's house, and from the roof he sees a woman bathing (11:2). The gaze from the roof leads to adultery and to the arranged death of her husband. The prophet Nathan then tells the king a story about a rich man who, rather than take from his own flocks, seized a poor man's only ewe lamb; David, enraged, condemns the rich man to death, and Nathan replies: "Thou art the man" (12:7). The technician's revelation on the roof of Life Extension has the structure of Nathan's parable. The protagonist has been listening to the story of his own persecution, and he is told that its author is himself.

The child born of the king's adultery falls ill. David fasts and lies on the ground; when the child dies, he rises, washes, and eats, and to his astonished servants he explains: "Can I bring him back again? I shall go to him, but he shall not return to me" (12:23). It is the most concise formula of mourning in the Hebrew Bible, and it is the logic of the rooftop. The protagonist cannot bring Sofía back; he can only go toward the condition in which she is, mortality, and accept that she will not return to him.

§8.6

Siduri's counsel and the walls of Uruk

The Old Babylonian version of *Gilgamesh* preserves a speech absent from the later standard text. The alewife Siduri, keeper of a tavern at the edge of the world, tells the grieving hero that when the gods created mankind they allotted death to it and kept life for themselves; let him fill his belly, make merry day and night, wear clean garments, cherish the child who holds his hand, and let his wife delight in his embrace, for this is the lot of humankind. Gilgamesh does not accept her counsel then; he crosses the waters of death, fails Utnapishtim's test of wakefulness, loses the plant of youth, and returns home. The epic's last lines repeat its first: he shows the ferryman the walls of Uruk, its brickwork, its gardens and its temple precinct.

The ending supplies the films' deepest mythic logic. The hero's consolation for mortality is not a beloved but a city, a work held in common, built by many hands and surviving each of them. Arendt described the Greek polis as a kind of organized remembrance (*The Human Condition*, § 27), a space in which deeds and words outlast those who perform them. Gilgamesh turns from personal immortality to the common world; Gracián's pilgrims enter the Isle of Immortality only through the memory of others (Chapter I). The protagonist leaps into a world that is not his, a world of strangers' works, toward the only immortality a mortal has: a place among others.

§8.7

The space of choices

Modern fiction has mapped the full space of answers to Calypso. In William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984), the hacker Case is trapped by an artificial intelligence on a simulated beach with a reconstruction of his dead girlfriend, Linda Lee, and invited to stay; he walks away. In Tarkovsky's *Solaris* (1972), the scientist Kelvin chooses the opposite: the final shot reveals that the father's house before which he kneels stands on an island formed by the ocean that manufactured his dead wife. In Michel Gondry and Charlie Kaufman's *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* (2004), two lovers who have had their memories of each other erased learn of the erasure and of the failure that preceded it, and choose to begin again anyway; the film's last exchange consists of a single word of assent. In "San Junipero" (*Black Mirror*, 2016), a dying woman, after long refusal out of loyalty to a husband who had himself refused, chooses to pass permanently into a simulated afterlife. The title of Gondry and Kaufman's film comes from Pope's "Eloisa to Abelard" (1717):

FIG.8.2 · THE SPACE OF CHOICES

Answers to Calypso's offer from myth, fiction, film and the philosophical ledger of Chapter II.

"How happy is the blameless vestal's lot! / The world forgetting, by the world forgot. / Eternal sunshine of the spotless mind!" Pope's line is the motto of Ogygia, and the diptych's answer to it is Odysseus'.

§8.8

The price: Honi's risk

The heteroprosopic choice has a price that the films do not conceal, and this dissertation must not conceal it either. Chapter II recalled Honi the Circle-Drawer, who woke after seventy years into a world that would not recognize him and died for want of companionship. The protagonist leaps toward a future in which no one knows his face. The common world he chooses is not guaranteed to receive him; the faces that can refuse him may do so. That risk is not a defect of his choice but its substance. A world in which others can refuse you is a world in which they may. The idiocosm's one real advantage over the common world is that in it no one will ever fail to recognize you, because everyone in it is you. The leap gives that advantage up. Where Gilgamesh failed the test of wakefulness, the protagonist passes it,

knowing that what he wakes into may not wake to him. The heroism of the Ogygian threshold lies in accepting that asymmetry.

IX

Which Dreamed It?

Undecidability, the Final Eye, and the Ethics of the Wager

§9.1

The circle that does not close

Both films end where they began: darkness, a woman's voice, the imperative to open the eyes. *Vanilla Sky* adds a final image, an eye opening in extreme close-up. The symmetry admits two readings. In the first, the circle is an exit: the protagonist wakes, at last, in the real world of the twenty-second century, and the voice belongs to a technician or a nurse. In the second, the circle is a loop: the voice that opens the film and the voice that closes it are the same, the ending is a return to the beginning, and the "real world" into which he wakes is the first scene of another dream. The films do not decide. This chapter argues that their refusal to decide is not an evasion but their most rigorous philosophical move, and that the decision they withhold at the level of knowledge they make at the level of action.

§9.2

The recursion of the awakener

The deepest form of the problem is not whether one is dreaming but whether the one who tells you that you are dreaming is himself a dream-figure. Zhuangzi stated it in the second chapter of the book that bears his name, the *Qiwulun*, in a passage less famous than the butterfly but more radical. Only after the great awakening, the sage Zhangwuzi says, will one know that this was the great dream; yet fools think they are awake and know it all. Confucius and you are both dreaming, he tells his interlocutor, and when I say you are dreaming, I am dreaming too. The butterfly passage that closes the chapter, in which Zhuang Zhou dreams he is a butterfly and on waking cannot tell whether he is a man who dreamt he was a butterfly or a butterfly dreaming he is a man, ends with a name for the condition: *wuhua*, the transformation of things.

Zhuangzi's recursion strips the technician of authority. The figure on the roof who tells the protagonist that he is dreaming is a content of the dream; his testimony has exactly the epistemic standing of any other dream-figure's. Lewis Carroll dramatized the same predicament in *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871). Tweedledee shows Alice the Red King asleep and tells her that he is dreaming about her, and that if he left off dreaming she would be nowhere, being only a sort of thing in his dream. The book's last chapter is titled "Which Dreamed It?" and leaves the question with the reader. The analyst of both films, informed by the technician that he is a figment, is in Alice's position before the Red King, and so is the protagonist before the technician.

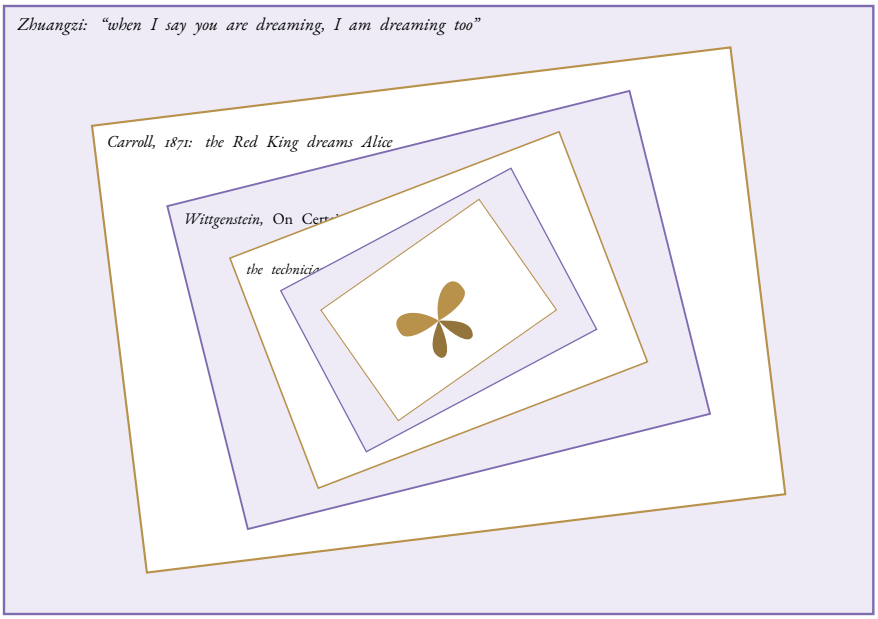


FIG. 9.1 · WHICH DREAMED IT?

The recursion of the awakener: whoever tells you that you are dreaming may be a figure in the dream.

Wittgenstein closed the circle with a remark from his last notebooks: the argument "I may be dreaming" is senseless because "if I am dreaming, this remark is being dreamed as well," and it is also being dreamed that the words have any meaning (*On Certainty*, § 383). The skeptical hypothesis undermines the language in which it is stated. Applied to the rooftop, the remark is devastating: if the protagonist is dreaming, the technician's explanation is dreamed too, and so is its sense.

§9.3

Criteria and their failure

The philosophical tradition offered criteria for distinguishing dream from waking, and the films test each. Descartes, having raised the dream argument in the First Meditation, answered it in the Sixth with a criterion of coherence: there is a great difference between dreaming and waking, *in eo quod nunquam insomnia cum reliquis omnibus actionibus vitae a memoria conjungantur*, in that dreams are never joined by memory with all the other actions of life. Leibniz, in a short paper on distinguishing real phenomena from imaginary ones, added vividness, multiplicity, internal congruence and, decisively, predictive success. The films' dream fails Descartes'

test by design: memory cannot join the restored face to the evidence that it was never restored. But the coherence criterion can only be applied from within one's present state, and the films' narrative structure (an interrogation in which memories are reassembled) shows that coherence can be manufactured retrospectively.

Michel Foucault (*Histoire de la folie*, 1961) argued that Descartes, in the First Meditation, excludes madness from the space of doubt, dismissing the insane with a curt *sed amentes sunt isti*, "but they are madmen," while admitting dreams. Jacques Derrida replied ("Cogito et histoire de la folie," 1963) that the dream argument, and still more the evil genius, radicalizes rather than excludes madness: total doubt is a hyperbole madder than any madman. The films stage the debate as plot. The psychiatric frame offers the hypothesis of madness, embodied by the analyst and the asylum; the technician offers the hypothesis of the dream. The protagonist is forced to choose between Foucault's diagnosis and Derrida's hyperbole, and the films do not tell us which he should prefer.

Schopenhauer proposed the most elegant resolution: life and dreams are leaves of one and the same book; reading them in order is called real life, while leafing through at random, now here, now there, is dreaming (*Die Welt als Wille und Vorstellung* I, § 5). The distinction lies not in the pages but in the coherence of the reading. The films' narrative order, with its flashbacks, interrogations and splices, is a book read out of order, and the leap is the decision to read the next page in sequence. Nietzsche, finally, drew the most corrosive conclusion. In *Götzen-Dämmerung* (1889) he traced how the "true world" became a fable, and concluded: *mit der wahren Welt haben wir auch die scheinbare abgeschafft*, with the true world we have abolished the apparent one as well. If there is no true world, there is no dream either, and the protagonist's leap from appearance to reality is a metaphysical naïveté. Earlier, in *Die Geburt der Tragödie* (§ 1), Nietzsche had recorded the experience of dreamers who, in the midst of terror, cry out *Es ist ein Traum! Ich will ihn weiter träumen!*: it is a dream, I will dream on. Nietzsche's dreamer is the anti-protagonist: lucid, and therefore content to remain.

§9.4

The science of the false awakening

The empirical study of dreaming has made the loop concrete. The false awakening, in which the dreamer dreams of waking and continues dreaming, is a well-documented phenomenon. Richard Linklater's *Waking Life* (2001), released three months before *Vanilla Sky*, made it the structure of an entire film: its protagonist wakes repeatedly into further dreams, tests his state by flipping light switches

that do not work, and wonders whether he is a consciousness in its last moments. Thomas Metzinger (*The Ego Tunnel*, 2009) argues that waking consciousness is itself an online simulation constrained by sensory input; Jennifer Windt (*Dreaming*, 2015) defines dreams as immersive spatiotemporal hallucinations; Ernest Sosa (*A Virtue Epistemology*, 2007) argues that dream states are imaginings rather than beliefs, which weakens the skeptic's analogy. Nick Bostrom ("Are You Living in a Computer Simulation?", 2003) argues that at least one of three propositions must be true, the third being that we almost certainly live in a simulation. Hilary Putnam (*Reason, Truth and History*, 1981) argued that a brain in a vat could not truly say it was one, because its words would refer to the vat's images rather than to vats. None of these positions closes the loop; each describes it.

Norman Malcolm (*Dreaming*, 1959) argued on conceptual grounds that one cannot judge, within a dream, that one is dreaming, and that dream reports are not reports of experiences had during sleep. The eye-signalling experiments of Hearne and LaBerge (Chapter III) are commonly taken as an empirical answer: dreamers judged that they were dreaming and said so, in the only language left to a paralysed body, with their eyes.

A more unsettling hypothesis concerns the time of the dream itself. Alfred Maury reported in 1861 a long dream of the Revolutionary Terror ending with his own execution by guillotine, from which he woke to find that the bed's headboard had fallen on his neck; he concluded that the entire narrative had been composed in the instant of the stimulus. Edmond Goblot (1896) proposed that dreams are generally composed at the moment of waking, and Freud discussed both in the *Traumdeutung*. Daniel Dennett ("Are Dreams Experiences?", 1976) revived the idea as the cassette theory: dreams might be stored as unexperienced narratives and inserted into memory at waking. Ambrose Bierce's "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" (1890), Borges' "El milagro secreto" (1943), Herk Harvey's *Carnival of Souls* (1962) and Adrian Lyne's *Jacob's Ladder* (1990) are fictions of this structure: an extended life composed in the instant of death. Under Maury's hypothesis, the entire film could be the narrative composed at the instant of the final eye, a guillotine dream generated by the impact of waking. The films' last image would then be not their conclusion but their cause.

§9.5

Comparative oneirology: sublation, sheaths, bardos

The Indic traditions supply concepts for the loop that Western philosophy lacks. The *Māṇḍūkya Upaniṣad* distinguishes four states: waking (*jāgrat*), dreaming (*svapna*), dreamless sleep (*suṣupti*), and the fourth (*turīya*), the witness of all three. Gauḍapāda's commentary (*Māṇḍūkya Kārikā* II) argued that the objects of waking are as unreal as those of dreams. Śaṅkara resisted the full assimilation, arguing against the Buddhist idealists (*Brahmasūtrabhāṣya* II.2.29) that waking cognitions are not sublated in the way dreams are, and supplying the key concept: *bādha*, sublation, the correction of one cognition by a later one, as the snake seen at dusk is sublated by the rope seen in daylight. The films are a sequence of sublations: the restored face sublated by the persecutor, the persecutor by the technician's revelation, the dream by the leap. The question of the ending is whether the series of sublations terminates, or whether, as Advaita holds of all empirical states short of liberation, every waking is provisional.

The *Taittirīya Upaniṣad* (II.1–5) describes the self as enclosed in five sheaths (*kośa*): of food, of breath, of mind, of understanding, and innermost of bliss, *ānandamaya kośa*. Vedāntic teaching holds that even the sheath of bliss is a covering to be passed through, not the self it covers. The word *vanilla* derives from Spanish *vainilla*, little pod, diminutive of *vaina*, sheath, from Latin *vāgīna*, a scabbard. The title thus names, without intending to, a sheath: the dream as a pod of bliss enclosing the sleeper, the cryonic capsule as a *vaina*. The leap is the shedding of the *ānandamaya kośa*, the last and most beautiful covering. It is also, through the Latin root, a birth: the passage out of a sheath that is also a womb, consistent with the reading of the leap as natality in Chapter VII.

Vasubandhu's *Viṃśatikā* (Twenty Verses) defended the Yogācāra thesis that experience is representation only with the example of the guardians of hell: the beings who torment the damned are not independent creatures but appearances produced by the damned's own karmic residue, which is why all the damned see the same guardians. The persecutor of the films is a hell-guardian in Vasubandhu's sense, produced by the protagonist's residue of guilt. Yet Chapter V argued that she is also the dream's only point of contact with a real other. The two claims are compatible: the persecutor is the form that the dreamer's karma, his debt to a real woman, takes in a world where only he exists.

Chinese and Indian narrative supply the purchased lifetime in its oldest literary form, and its instrument is a pillow. In Shen Jiji's Tang tale "Zhenzhong ji" (*The World Inside a Pillow*, eighth century), a poor scholar lies down at an inn on a pillow

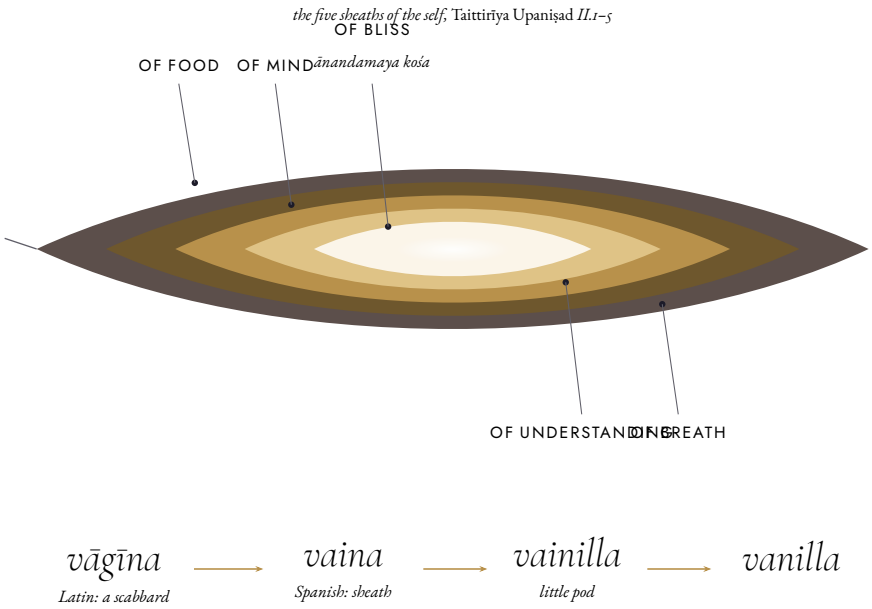


FIG. 9.2 · VANILLA: THE LITTLE SHEATH

The five sheaths of the self, and the Latin root that makes the film's title the name of a covering. The leap sheds the last and most beautiful one.

lent him by a Daoist and lives a whole career (examinations, office, exile, honours, sons, old age and death), then wakes to find that the millet the innkeeper set to cook is not yet done. Li Gongzuo's "Nanke taishou zhuan" (*The Governor of the Southern Branch*) gives a sleeper a kingdom, a princess and a disgrace inside an ant colony beneath a tree. In a Purāṇic story, the sage Nārada asks Viṣṇu to show him *māyā*; sent to fetch water, he marries, raises children, loses them all in a flood, and wakes to find the god still waiting for his drink. The *Yoga Vāsiṣṭha* tells of King Lavaṇa, who lives decades as an outcaste during a moment's trance. In the Tang tale the pillow is the instrument of the dream-life; in the films a pillow is the instrument of the dream-murder. The object that bore a lifetime of illusion in the Chinese tradition becomes, in the diptych, the means of covering the one face that resisted the illusion.

The *Bardo Thödol*, the Tibetan liberation through hearing in the intermediate state, revealed according to tradition by Karma Lingpa in the fourteenth century and introduced to the West by W. Y. Evans-Wentz (1927) with a commentary by Jung, describes the dead person's passage through three intermediate states. In the first, at the moment of death, the clear light dawns. In the second, peaceful deities appear, then wrathful ones; the text, read aloud beside the body, urges the dead to

recognize them all as projections of their own mind, for recognition is liberation. In the third, the dead seek rebirth and must choose a womb wisely. The films follow this sequence with startling fidelity: after the death, a peaceful vision (Sofía's return); then a wrathful one (the persecutor); then a voice that explains that both are the dreamer's projections; then the choice of a rebirth into a new world. The voice that whispers "open your eyes" is the voice of the lama reading beside the body. Lyne's *Jacob's Ladder*, whose writer Bruce Joel Rubin drew on the Tibetan text, makes the same structure explicit through a speech the film attributes to Meister Eckhart: those who cling to life see devils tearing it away, while those at peace see that the devils are angels freeing them.

The Islamic mystical tradition gives the loop its most audacious formulation. A saying attributed in Sufi literature to the Prophet or to ʿAlī holds that people are asleep, and when they die, they awaken. Ibn ʿArabī, in the chapter on Joseph of the *Fuṣūṣ al-ḥikam* (1229), cites it to argue that the whole of existence is imagination (*khayāl*) to be interpreted like a dream, and that death is the beginning of interpretation. Henry Corbin (1958) reconstructed from this the *mundus imaginalis*, an intermediate world neither material nor merely fantastic. On this view the films' equation of death with waking is not a science-fiction device but one of the oldest doctrines of the Abrahamic mystical traditions.

§9.6

The wager

If the ontological question cannot be settled, the decision must be made on other grounds. Calderón's Segismundo supplies the ground (Chapter I): *sea verdad o sueño, / obrar bien es lo que importa; / si fuere verdad, por serlo; / si no, por ganar amigos / para cuando despertemos*. The formula is a wager with two branches. If the world is real, act well because it is real; if it is a dream, act well in order to gain friends for when we wake. Both branches recommend the same action, and the second branch defines the good socially: virtue under uncertainty is the acquisition of others.

Pascal's wager (*Pensées*, Lafuma 418) has the same structure, and Pascal also understood the economics of dreams exactly as Life Extension does. If we dreamed the same thing every night, he wrote, it would affect us as much as what we see every day; an artisan sure of dreaming every night for twelve hours that he was king would be almost as happy as a king who dreamed every night for twelve hours that he was an artisan (Lafuma 803). Pascal described the firm's business model three centuries

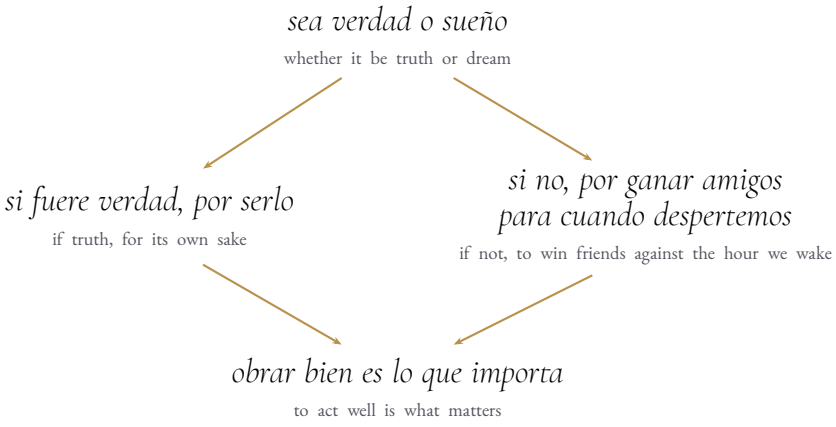


FIG.9.3 · CALDERÓN'S WAGER

Both branches recommend the same action; the second defines the good socially, as the gaining of others.

early, and used it to argue that the stakes of our choices cannot be settled by the quality of our experiences.

William James ("The Will to Believe," 1896) gave the wager its modern justification. When an option is living, forced and momentous, and cannot by its nature be decided on intellectual grounds, "our passional nature not only lawfully may, but must, decide." The rooftop is James' genuine option in its purest form. It is living, because both alternatives are real possibilities to the protagonist. It is forced, because there is no third course. It is momentous, because it is unique, irreversible and decisive for his whole existence. And it cannot be decided intellectually, for the reasons Zhuangzi and Wittgenstein gave.

The heteroprosopic wager is Calderón's formula translated into the terms of this dissertation. Under ontological undecidability, choose the world in which faces can refuse you. If that world is real, you have chosen reality for its own sake. If it is another dream, you have chosen a dream that at least contains the possibility of an unauthored face, and you have gained, in Segismundo's phrase, the habit of seeking friends against the hour you wake. Keats wrote that the imagination may be compared to Adam's dream: he awoke and found it truth (letter to Benjamin Bailey, 22 November 1817), alluding to *Paradise Lost* VIII, where Adam dreams Eve's creation and wakes to find her real. The protagonist's wager is the inverse of Adam's dream. He does not expect to wake and find the beloved; he expects to lose her.

What he expects to find is a world in which she, or someone, could be found, and could refuse to be.

X

Translatio Somnii

The Remake as Life Extension and the Sofia Constant

§10.1

The remake as philosophical content

The relation between *Abre los ojos* and *Vanilla Sky* has usually been treated as a matter of reception: a question of fidelity, quality or cultural appropriation. This chapter treats it as a matter of content. Its claim is that the remake relation reproduces, at the level of film production, the structure the films narrate at the level of plot, and that this homology is the diptych's self-allegory. *Vanilla Sky* is Hollywood's lucid dream of *Abre los ojos*.

Remake theory supplies the frame. Thomas Leitch ("Twice-Told Tales: The Rhetoric of the Remake," 1990) distinguished the readaptation, the update, the homage and the "true remake," which seeks to supersede its model while disavowing dependence on it. Lucy Mazdon (*Encore Hollywood*, 2000) analysed the American remaking of French cinema as a transfer across industrial and national cultures, neither simple theft nor simple tribute. Jennifer Forrest and Leonard Koos titled their collection on the remake *Dead Ringers* (2002), a phrase that names both an exact double and the bell rung for the buried who wake; Constantine Verevis (*Film Remakes*, 2006) treated the remake as a category constituted by industry, text and critical discourse together. *Vanilla Sky* is a close remake of an unusual kind: the remake rights were acquired by Tom Cruise's production company after he saw Amenábar's film, the original's director was within the same production circle (Cruise was an executive producer of Amenábar's *Los otros*, released the same year), and one actor was carried over in her role. The remake was not an appropriation at arm's length but a resuscitation performed with the original's body in the room.

§10.2

Benjamin: translation as afterlife

Walter Benjamin's "Die Aufgabe des Übersetzers" (1923) supplies the remake's metaphysics. A translation, Benjamin argued, does not serve the reader who cannot read the original; it issues from the original's afterlife, its *Überleben* and *Fortleben*, in which the original's life attains its latest and most extensive unfolding. Works have lives, and translations are the stages of their survival. Benjamin added that translations together point toward a "pure language" (*reine Sprache*) that no single language contains, as fragments of a broken vessel point to the vessel.

Read with Benjamin, the remake is literally a life extension. A Spanish film, completed in 1997, is suspended and revived four years later in another language, another city and another industry, its body (the story) preserved and its face (the

cast) replaced. Benjamin's *Fortleben* is the cryonic premise transposed to works of art. And the two films together point toward something neither contains, a pure film of which each is a fragment: the diptych as Benjamin's broken vessel. This dissertation has been reading that vessel.

Jacques Derrida's essay on Benjamin, "Des Tours de Babel" (1985), places translation under the sign of a tower. Babel is the edifice whose interruption scattered humanity into languages and made translation necessary and impossible at once. The diptych ends on a tower, and its hero falls from it into a world of others. Barbara Cassin's *Vocabulaire européen des philosophies* (2004) defined the untranslatable not as what cannot be translated but as what one never ceases to translate. The diptych's untranslatable is a person.

§10.3

The Sofía constant

Penélope Cruz plays Sofía in both films, the only performer to carry her role from Madrid to Manhattan. In the plot, the splice is the point at which the purchased dream is joined to the real biography: the night in the street, after which Sofía returns. In the production, Cruz is the splice between the films: the point at which the American dream of the film is joined to its Spanish original. She is the element of *Abre los ojos* that *Vanilla Sky* did not author. Crowe could rewrite every scene, transpose every location, replace every other face; he inherited hers.

This gives the remake relation a heteroprosopic structure. Within the dream, the only unauthored face is the persecutor's (Chapter V). Within the remake, the only unauthored face is the beloved's. And in *Vanilla Sky*, the opening whisper of "open your eyes" is attached to her voice: the original, through its one surviving face, calls the remake to wake. Her accented English, the trace of the language the film left behind, keeps the original audible inside its translation. The *Sofía constant* is this dissertation's name for that persistence: the guarantee, within an industrial process of re-dreaming, that something real survived the translation. The remake does not collapse into a pure idiocosm, as its hero's dream does, because it kept one face it did not make.

The star-text extended the constant beyond the screen, in the sense Richard Dyer gives that term. In 2001 the public separation of Cruise from Nicole Kidman, star of *Los otros*, and the beginning of his much-publicized relationship with Cruz formed part of the films' cultural reception. Criticism need not dwell on the private lives of performers to observe that the boundary between the stars' publicized lives and their roles was, in this case, conspicuously porous, and that the publicity apparatus that

sells stars as continuous persons is a minor branch of the industry Life Extension represents.

§10.4

Madrid to Manhattan: the archive as dream-matter

The transposition changes the dream's material. Amenábar, who composed his own score, built a dream of austere surfaces: an empty main street, institutional interiors, a soundscape under a single author's control. Crowe, a former *Rolling Stone* journalist whose films are organized around popular music, built his dream from the American archive. The soundtrack (with a score by Nancy Wilson) opens on Radiohead's "Everything in Its Right Place" (2000), whose title could serve as the idiocosm's motto, and includes Sigur Rós' "Svefn-g-englar," whose title fuses the Icelandic words for sleepwalker and angels, Peter Gabriel's "Solsbury Hill" (Chapter III), and Paul McCartney's title song. The images quote the archive too: David and Sofía walk down a snowy street restaging the cover of Bob Dylan's *The Freewheelin' Bob Dylan* (1963); the sky that names the film is borrowed from a Monet the protagonist owns; Julie's deliberate crash, an attempted murder-suicide, recalls Catherine driving her car off a broken bridge with Jim beside her, killing them both, at the end of *Jules et Jim* (1962).

This saturation is often treated as Crowe's signature or his indulgence. It is better understood as the precise content of the idiocosm. A dream composed by a man who owns a publishing empire is assembled from the commodities of the culture industry he serves: album covers, pop songs, paintings in his collection, films of his childhood. Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer described the culture industry as mass deception that pre-schematizes the consumer's experience (*Dialektik der Aufklärung*, 1944/1947); Hortense Powdermaker's anthropology of Hollywood called it *The Dream Factory* (1950); Guy Debord opened *La Société du spectacle* (1967) by describing modern life as "an immense accumulation of spectacles," a social relation among people mediated by images. Fredric Jameson (*Postmodernism*, 1991) identified the "nostalgia mode," a pastiche of past styles standing in for a history that can no longer be represented. Mark Fisher, extending Derrida's hauntology and Franco Berardi's phrase, diagnosed a "slow cancellation of the future" in which culture endlessly recycles the forms of lost futures (*Capitalist Realism*, 2009; *Ghosts of My Life*, 2014).

Vanilla Sky's dream is the hauntological dream par excellence. A man suspends his future by freezing himself, and dreams in the forms of the 1960s and 1970s, the decade of Dylan's cover and the pop that promised other futures. The cancellation

of the future that Fisher described as a cultural condition is here a literal contract. Crowe's archive is thus not decoration but diagnosis: the remake shows, through its very texture, what a private world assembled from the culture industry looks like, and the answer is that it looks like *Vanilla Sky*. The remake dramatizes what it is.

§10.5

Cratylic onomastics

The transposition also renames, and the renamings form a system (in the sense of the Introduction's method: resonance, not intention).

- **César → David.** The Spanish hero bears the name of the Roman dictator whose name became the word for emperor: *César* is sovereignty, the tyrant of Chapter VI. The American hero bears the Hebrew name *Dāwīd*, traditionally glossed "beloved," and the name of the king who walked on his roof and saw a woman bathing, and to whom Nathan said "Thou art the man" (Chapter VIII). The remake converts the sovereign into the beloved, the tyrant who wants to rule into the narcissist who wants to be loved, and gives him a rooftop.
- **The Julian name migrates.** Caesar belonged to the *gens Iulia*. In the remake the hero loses Caesar's name, and the Julian name passes to the woman who destroys him: Julie.
- **Nuria.** The Spanish persecutor bears a Catalan name taken from the Marian sanctuary of Núria in the Pyrenees, whose etymology is disputed; it is popularly, though not securely, glossed through Arabic *nūr*, light. If the gloss is accepted, the persecutor is the bearer of light in the dream: the figure through whom reality shows.
- **Sofía.** Wisdom, *sophia*, the Gnostic aeon and Jung's highest anima (Chapter III), constant across both versions.
- **Pelayo → Brian.** The Spanish friend bears the name of the Asturian king traditionally credited with beginning the Christian reconquest at Covadonga (c. 722): the founder of a common political world. The remake's friend loses that name and becomes, in the dream, a projection.
- **Antonio → Curtis McCabe.** The Spanish analyst bears the name of Saint Anthony, patron of hallucinatory temptation in the desert, whose night of visions Flaubert's *La Tentation de saint Antoine* (1874) ends at dawn with the face of Christ shining in the disc of the sun.

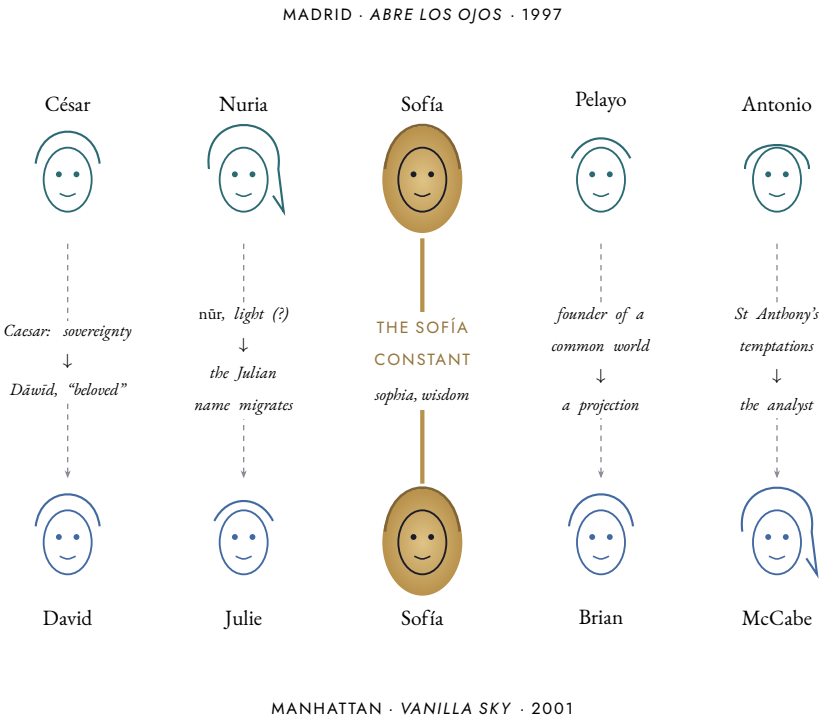


FIG.10.1 · THE SOFÍA CONSTANT

Every face is replaced in the passage from Madrid to Manhattan except one. The renamings form a system: resonance, not intention.

- **The technician: Edmund Ventura.** *Ventura* is fortune, chance; *buenaventura* in Spanish is the telling of fortunes. The figure who reveals the protagonist's fate bears the name of fortune-telling.
- **Rebecca Dearborn.** The corporate officer who sells the product carries in her surname the word *born*: the vendor of rebirth.
- **Life Extension.** The name echoes the Alcor Life Extension Foundation (Chapter II) and McLuhan's "extensions of man" (Chapter VI).
- **Vanilla.** *Vainilla*, little sheath (Chapter IX).

FIG.10.2 · ANNUS ONEIRICUS

The millennial cycle of dream films that 2001 capped.

§10.6

2001: annus oneiricus

The remake belongs to a year that might be called the *annus oneiricus* of American and European cinema. In 2001 there appeared, besides *Vanilla Sky*: *Mulholland Drive*, whose heroine's dream of Hollywood success collapses into the reality of failure and guilt (Chapter VI); *Waking Life*, a film of false awakenings (Chapter IX); *A.I. Artificial Intelligence*, whose robot David is frozen for two millennia and granted a manufactured day with a reconstructed mother (Chapter II); Amenábar's own *Los otros*, whose heroine and children are dead and do not know it; *Donnie Darko*, whose hero accepts death to restore a primary universe; and, in American release, *Memento*, whose amnesiac hero deliberately deceives his own future self to give his life a purpose. The year capped a millennial cycle that included *Dark City* and *The Truman Show* (1998), *The Matrix*, *eXistenZ*, *The Thirteenth Floor*, *Fight Club*, *Being John Malkovich* and *Eyes Wide Shut* (1999), and that ran on to *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* (2004).

The convergence has historical causes that can be named without reducing the films to them: the arrival of the consumer internet and the first popular discourse of virtual reality; the post-Cold War announcement of an end of history, which left a future without alternatives; and the new digital image, which severed the photograph's index from the world. In this cycle *Vanilla Sky* holds a particular position. Most of its companions end inside their illusions or in tragic recognition. The two Davids of 2001 frame the alternatives: Spielberg's robot David accepts the manufactured day and sleeps; Crowe's human David refuses the manufactured eternity and wakes. The *annus oneiricus* produced, in its last month, its most explicit refusal of the dream.

§10.7

Conclusion

The remake relation completes the diptych's argument by extending it to cinema itself. Hollywood, the dream factory, purchased the rights to a Spanish dream and redreamed it with its own materials, its own star and its own archive. Had it replaced everything, the remake would have been an idiocosm: a world made entirely by its new owner. It kept one face. The Sofía constant is the remake's heteroprosopic guarantee, the point at which Crowe's film, like its hero's dream at the persecutor's face, touches something it did not make, and the reason it can be read not as a copy but as the second half of a single work.

CONCLUSION

The Heteroprosopic Test

Waking in the Age of Synthetic Faces

§C.1

Results

This dissertation has argued that *Abre los ojos* and *Vanilla Sky* form a single work whose subject is not the uncertainty of perception but the reality of others. Its findings can be stated as results.

1. **The dream fails ethically, not epistemically.** The purchased world is phenomenally flawless and breaks only at the beloved's face. The films transpose the skeptical problem from knowledge to acknowledgment (Introduction; Chapter V).
2. **The contract is an Endymion contract.** It sells eternal sleep as eternal life, conditioned on forgetting (the Lethe clause) and on ignorance of oneself (the Tiresian clause), and it fails as Freud's 1900 theory of the dream failed in 1920 (Chapter II).
3. **The call is Sophianic.** The faceless voice that opens and closes both films gathers the Gnostic call from beyond, Heidegger's call of conscience and Levinas' Saying, and it is physiologically exact: the eye is the dream's only door (Chapter III).
4. **The ruined face is a prosopoclasm.** It ejects the protagonist from the economy of the star-face and from the faciality machine, and the mask is prosopopoeia made prosthetic (Chapter IV).
5. **The persecutor is the dream's truth.** She is the only face in the idiocosm that refuses, survives, looks back and belongs to a common past; the murder by suffocation is the idiocosm's essential gesture (Chapter V).
6. **The dreamer is a tyrant.** The lucid dream is the political form of absolute sovereignty over phantoms, consumer sovereignty perfected, and it reconstitutes against its sovereign the law it abolished (Chapter VI).
7. **The two deaths form a chiasmus.** The first is philosophical suicide sold as a service; the second inverts it into lucidity and natality (Chapter VII).
8. **The rooftop is Ogygia's shore.** The protagonist makes Odysseus' choice and Achilles' verdict, at the risk of Honi's fate (Chapter VIII).
9. **The ending is undecidable, and the decision is ethical.** Under undecidability, the films restore Calderón's wager in a heteroprosopic form: choose the world in which faces can refuse you (Chapter IX).

10 **The remake is the work's self-allegory.** *Vanilla Sky* is Hollywood's lucid dream of *Abre los ojos*, saved from idiocosmic collapse by the one face it did not author (Chapter X).

The four conditions of heteroprosopic realism (refusal, survival, regard, commonality) organize these results. They also define a test that extends beyond the films.

§C.2

The test

The Life Extension corporation was a fiction in 1997 and 2001. A quarter-century later, several of its product lines exist in partial form. Carl Öhman and Luciano Floridi (2017) described a "digital afterlife industry" of firms that profit from the data and online presence of the dead. Tomasz Hollanek and Katarzyna Nowaczyk-Basińska (2024) analysed "griefbots" and "deadbots," conversational simulations of deceased persons generated from their digital traces, and proposed safeguards against their misuse. In 2020 the Korean broadcaster MBC aired *Meeting You*, a documentary in which a mother, wearing a virtual-reality headset, met a reconstruction of her young daughter, who had died years before. Companion applications built on large language models now offer, by subscription, partners who are always available, always attentive and incapable of leaving. Commercial cryonics continues. Crary's last uncolonized interval, sleep, is monitored by devices worn to bed. The Life Extension contract has been rewritten as a set of terms of service.

The law has begun to meet the contract. In *Re JS* (2016), the High Court of England and Wales allowed the mother of a fourteen-year-old girl dying of cancer to arrange the cryopreservation the girl had asked for, the judge stressing that the case concerned a dispute between parents over the disposal of a body and not the merits of cryonics.

The films do not counsel technophobia. Their objection is not to the virtual, the artificial or the prosthetic as such (Chalmers is right that virtual objects can be real and virtual lives meaningful) but to the idiocosmic: to worlds and relationships in which every other is authored by the one who uses them. The four conditions therefore yield four questions that can be put to any technology of simulated intimacy or experience.

- **Refusal.** Can the face in this system say no to its user, in ways the user did not configure and cannot override?
- **Survival.** Does it persist independently of its user's use, destruction, revision or deletion of it? Does it have a life the user does not maintain?

	REFUSAL	SURVIVAL	REGARD	COMMONALITY
Sofía in the dream *authored by the dreamer · an idiocosm*	○	○	○	○
Nuria; Julie, the persecutor *the dream's one unauthored face · the dream's truth*	●	●	●	●
A griefbot *configured by the bereaved, held by one · an idiocosm*	○	○	○	○
A shared virtual world *inhabited by other persons · as real as any world*	●	●	●	●

FIG.C.1 · THE HETEROPROSOPIC TEST

The four conditions put to the dissertation's four cases. A filled mark means the condition is met.

- **Regard.** Does it look back on terms it sets, with a perspective the user did not supply?
- **Commonality.** Is it held in common with others who can see it, contest the user's account of it and be answerable to it?

A system that fails all four is an idiocosm, whatever its fidelity. A griefbot generated from a dead person's messages, configured by the bereaved and answerable to no one else, fails every condition: it cannot refuse, it does not survive deletion, its regard is a statistical echo of the user's own archive, and it is held by one person alone. It is, in the precise sense of this dissertation, Sofía in the dream. A shared virtual world inhabited by other persons can pass all four, and is therefore, by the heteroprosopic criterion, as real as any world. The test does not separate the natural from the artificial. It separates the common from the idiotic.

§C.3

A reflexive note

The present text was composed by an artificial interlocutor, a system of the kind the previous section examines, at the request of a human reader. It would be inconsistent to exempt it from its own test. Its arguments can be refused, and should be where they fail; its claims about films, texts and dates can and should be checked against the works themselves; its readings are offered to a common world of criticism in which they can be contested. If it has any value, that value lies in what survives that contestation, and in whatever the reader brings back from the films that it did not author. A thesis that asked to be believed without resistance would be a small idiocosm. This one asks to be argued with.

§C.4

The final eye

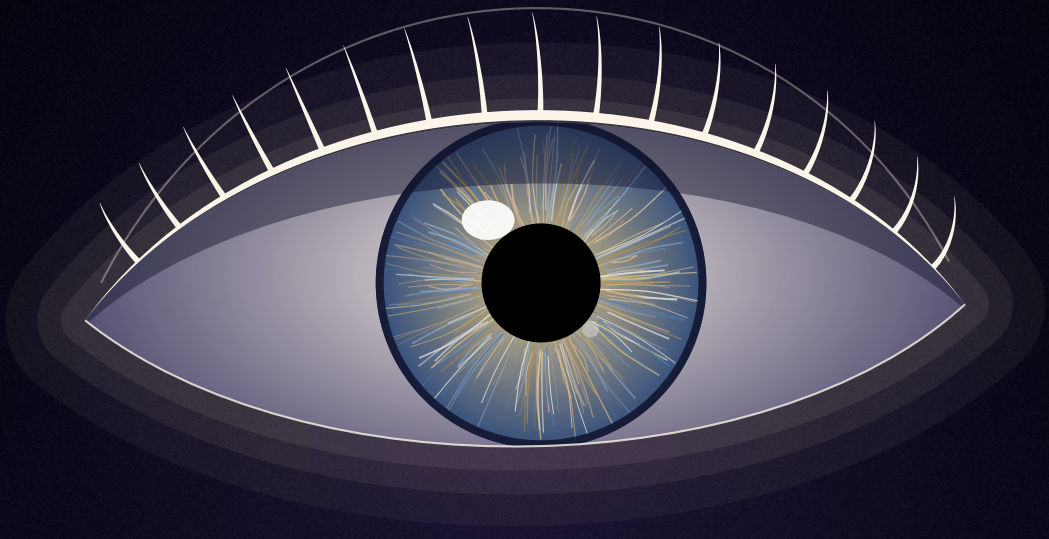
The films end on an eye opening after a voice in darkness. This dissertation has read that image as a summons (Chapter III), as the minimum of the face (Chapter IV), as a birth (Chapter VII), as a passage through the gate of horn or of ivory (Chapter VIII) and as the undecidable point of a wager (Chapter IX). It closes with three texts that the image recalls.

Paul placed the resurrection "in a moment, in the twinkling of an eye" (1 Corinthians 15:52), and named the difference between this life and the next as the difference between a mirror and a face: "For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face" (13:12). The idiocosm is the glass, a world of reflections in which every face returns one's own. What the protagonist leaps toward is not knowledge but the possibility of a face that is not his reflection.

Arendt found in natality the ground of every new beginning, and wrote that "the miracle that saves the world" from its natural ruin is ultimately the fact of natality (*The Human Condition*, § 34). The protagonist's leap does not save his world; it abandons it. But it makes him a newcomer, and newcomers are, for Arendt, the only source of the new.

Schnitzler ended *Traumnovelle* (1926), the source of the first panel of Cruise's ocular triptych, with a husband and wife who have survived a night in which neither can say what was dream and what was real. *Nun sind wir wohl erwacht*, she says, now we are awake, I think, *für lange*, for a long time. He wants to add "forever," but before he can say it she lays a finger on his lips and whispers, as if to herself: *Niemals in die Zukunft fragen*, never ask about the future. The wife's refusal of

"forever" is the ethic this dissertation has drawn from the diptych. Wakefulness is not eternal, and it cannot be guaranteed; it can only be chosen, for a long time, among others, without a warranty. Keats left the question where the films leave it: "Do I wake or sleep?" The films' answer is that this cannot be known, and that it is not the question. The question is whether, wherever we are, there is someone there who can look back.



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KEYWORDS

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